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Personality

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In 2003, various members of the United States Army tortured detainees at the Abu Ghraib prison in Iraq, engaging in horrific acts of physical, psychological, and sexual abuse. Leaked photographs depicting the brutalization of Iraqi prisoners sparked outrage in the U.S. (Hersh, 2004). In response, multiple U.S. military officials were removed from duty, and some were charged for their crimes. Specialist Charles "Chuck" Graner, the ringleader, committed some of the worst offenses and was convicted of assault, abuse, cruelty, and dereliction of duty, and sentenced to 10 years in prison. Why did Graner – and others like him – commit these war crimes?

Viewed through the lens of an extreme situationist perspective, Graner's behavior was caused by the violent prison environment, pervasive Islamophobia, dehumanization of the "other," and a military chain of command that promoted getting information from prisoners by any means necessary. In other words, Graner was a pawn of broader situational and systemic forces. As Zimbardo (2007) argued, "the military and civilian chain of command had built a "bad barrel' in which a bunch of good soldiers became transformed into 'bad apples'."

A hardcore trait psychologist, on the other hand, would downplay any role of the environment and instead highlight aspects of Graner's personality – his violent nature, sadistic tendencies, lack of self-control, and narcissistic desire for power. They would point to Graner's history of abuse, including domestic violence and putting a razor blade in the food of an inmate at the prison where he worked before joining the military, as well as the fact that most guards at the Abu Ghraib prison refrained from abusing prisoners. From this perspective, only individuals with violent, hostile, and antisocial personality traits would engage in abuse. In other words, it was a few rotten apples – a few rogue soldiers – not a rotten barrel that accounts for the shocking acts of violence perpetrated against the Iraqi prisoners.[1]

Decades ago, these two interpretations would have been pitted against each other: people's actions must be driven by either the situation or the person. Fortunately, we now recognize that both viewpoints are critically important for understanding human behavior. Indeed, few contemporary social psychologists would deny that people differ in how they respond to the same situation, and few contemporary personality psychologists would deny that situations have powerful effects on

behavior.[2] From this integrative perspective, Graner was a rotten apple (i.e., aggressive and hostile), and the Abu Ghraib prison was a rotten barrel, and combining the two created a particularly toxic mix.

With debates about the importance of persons and situations in the rearview mirror (Deaux & Snyder, 2018; Donnellan et al., 2009; Kenrick & Funder, 1988), contemporary social and personality psychologists now share a common goal – to understand all aspects of the person in all contexts. In many ways, the two areas form a natural alliance, with their collective investigation into the mutual influences of the person and the situation, and the myriad substantive topics that are of interest to both areas (e.g., achievement, aggression, culture, emotion, motivation, relationships, and self-esteem; Tracy et al., 2009a; 2012). Most researchers recognize that we cannot examine social processes without understanding the individuals experiencing and reacting to those processes; similarly, we cannot understand patterns of thoughts, feelings, and behaviors without understanding the unique situational contexts in which people are positioned. Consequently, we now find ourselves at a time when the field can work toward greater integration, or what Swann and Seyle (2005) labeled a "symbiotic" approach.

In the previous edition of *The Handbook of Social Psychology*, Funder and Fast (2010) described social and personality psychology as sibling sciences with a fraught relationship, despite their shared goals and complementary approaches. Like siblings, the two fields may argue and bicker, but we are deeply intertwined as part of the same family, through our professional identities, associations, and journals. In 2010, Funder and Fast noted that the estrangement between personality and social psychology "appear[ed] to be slowly ending" (p. 669). We are happy to report that, over a decade later, the two fields are more connected than ever.

OVERVIEW AND ROADMAP

Personality psychology focuses on understanding individual variability in people's thoughts, feelings, and behaviors: Why is one person shy and another outgoing, one person irritable and another even-tempered, and one person reliable and another irresponsible? Personality psychologists have a lofty goal – to understand the origins, development, and consequences of human individuality from the cradle to the grave. Working alongside social, clinical, developmental, and quantitative psychologists, personality researchers integrate perspectives from neuroscience, anthropology, sociology, economics, and philosophy and use a wide range of quantitative and qualitative methods to address broad and abiding questions about human nature: What are the building blocks of a person's individuality? Does a child's unique patterns of thoughts, feelings, and behaviors foretell the adult they will one day become? How do nature and nurture work together to shape a person's personality?

One of the hallmarks of the field is that such questions are investigated at multiple levels of analysis, from genes to socio-cultural contexts. Consequently, personality researchers use a broad array of methods, including self-report personality tests, informant reports, experience sampling/ecological momentary assessments, cognitive tasks, behavioral observation, and neurophysiological assessments. Individuals trained in personality psychology work at universities, private and federal research institutes, test publishing companies, tech companies, organizational consulting firms, and government agencies such as the CIA and FBI.

In the past few decades, we have seen a renaissance in the field driven by dramatic growth in the quality and breadth of personality research and a surge in real-world applications. Given its vast scope, writing a chapter on the entire field of personality is a nearly impossible task. For an in-depth perspective, we refer readers to the most recent edition of the *Handbook of Personality* (John & Robins, 2021), which includes 42 chapters on a diverse range of topics, including the molecular genetics and neural bases of personality, personality in non-human animals, personality development, narrative identity, cognitive approaches to personality, interventions to change personality, and the application of personality research to mental health, physical health, economics, and other areas.

Rather than provide a comprehensive review of the field, we will summarize what we have learned so far about the big questions that motivate current personality research. Although undergraduate courses in personality psychology often focus on the grand theories of Freud, Skinner, Maslow, Rogers, and others, these theories have little direct impact on contemporary research, and haven't for decades (Mendelsohn, 1993). Instead, most personality psychologists conduct research that addresses one or more of the following questions: (a) What are the basic building blocks of personality and how are they organized (*personality structure*)? (b) How can we best measure individual differences in personality (*personality assessment)*? (c) What are the developmental origins of personality and how does personality change across the lifespan (*personality development*)? (d) What are the biological, cognitive, emotional, self, social, and cultural factors that account for personality differences (*personality processes*)? (e) What are the real-world consequences of personality for important life outcomes (*personality applications*)? The bulk of this chapter will summarize recent findings and conclusions emerging from these five areas of personality research.[3]

After providing a birds-eye view of the field, we will apply what we have learned about personality research to better understand the case of Chuck Graner. We then turn to an issue that we believe impedes collaborative work between personality and social psychologists: lingering myths about the practice of personality psychology. In this context, we acknowledge some inconvenient truths about the limitations of the personality approach, at least as it is currently implemented in research. Next, we provide a point-by-point guide for non-personality psychologists interested in incorporating a personality approach in their research. Finally, we share our vision of a path forward to a more cooperative social-personality psychology, including specific recommendations for promoting collaboration.[4]

CURRENT RESEARCH IN PERSONALITY PSYCHOLOGY

What Are The Basic Building Blocks Of Personality And How Are They Organized?

The basic building blocks, or units, of personality have been conceptualized in a variety of ways by theorists from different perspectives: as defense mechanisms by psychodynamic theorists; as learned stimulus-response patterns by behaviorists; as information-processing tendencies by cognitively-oriented theorists; as motives, goals, and related constructs by motivational psychologists; as evolved neural systems by biologically-oriented theorists; as narrative identity by narrative researchers; and as traits by trait researchers. Despite the diversity of personality units

proposed by theorists, the vast majority of contemporary research in personality psychology focuses on (1) personality traits, (2) motives, and/or (3) narrative identity (McAdams, 1995).

Personality Traits

Traits are widely considered the primary building blocks of personality. They are typically defined as enduring patterns of thoughts, feelings, and behaviors that influence a person's interactions with, and adaptations to, the environment. For example, the personality trait of shyness is assumed to have a *cognitive component* (e.g., concerns about making a good impression; negative self-evaluation; excessive self-consciousness and rumination during social interactions), an *affective component* (e.g., feeling nervous, tense and uneasy in social situations; increased heart rate and "butterflies in the stomach"), and a *behavioral component* (e.g., avoiding social interaction, especially with strangers; difficulty speaking in front of others, avoiding eye contact, and other signs of behavioral inhibition). Each trait construct, whether of shyness, aggression, creativity, or self-control, is assumed to encompass all three components – cognitive, affective, and behavioral – of the "personality triad" (Funder, 2024).

One monumental task has been to identify and classify the vast array of traits on which individuals differ from each other. A surprisingly helpful starting point has been language itself. According to the *lexical hypothesis*, all of the important and socially relevant personality differences among people eventually become encoded into the language of all human cultures (Allport & Odbert, 1936; Goldberg, 1982). Using the logic of the lexical hypothesis, many personality psychologists believe that research examining how personality-related attributes (e.g., calm, talkative, dominant, kind) cluster together in languages around the world can provide insight into the number and nature of the basic units of personality.

Research accumulating over the past several decades suggests that five broad domains (referred to as the "Big Five") are needed to classify the personality trait terms that exist in most languages (John, 2021). Table 1 provides a description of each Big Five domain: Extraversion, Agreeableness, Conscientiousness, Neuroticism (vs Emotional Stability), and Openness to Experience. Each domain subsumes a cluster of conceptually and empirically interrelated traits; for example, people who are kind also tend to be caring, cooperative, and trusting, and the intercorrelations among these (and related) traits lead to the emergence of a statistical factor labeled Agreeableness. Thus, although researchers often describe the Big Five as individual dimensions, they are, in fact, broad domains comprising hundreds or thousands of individual traits.

***Table 1*: The Big Five Personality Taxonomy**

Big Five Domain	Associated Traits	Adaptive Benefits (Biobehavioral System)
Extraversion	Outgoing, talkative, sociable, assertive, active	Seeking mates, competing for resources and social rank (*Approach system*)
Agreeableness	Warm, kind, caring, cooperative, trusting	Bonding with mates, caring for offspring (*Caregiving system*)
Conscientiousness	Organized, responsible, punctual, industrious, dependable	Conforming to societal standards, showing discipline and persistence (*Self-regulation system*)
Neuroticism	Anxious, irritable, moody, tense, sad	Avoiding danger (*Avoidance system*)
Openness	Curious, creative, imaginative, intellectual, open to new ideas and experiences	Exploring, learning, innovating (*Exploratory system*)

The Big Five framework is agnostic about the theoretical origins of the personality domains, but each domain can be thought of as reflecting a specific underlying biobehavioral system (see Table 1). Specifically, the Extraversion domain is associated with the *approach system*, and may have evolved to facilitate seeking mates, increasing and maintaining social rank, and competing for resources; Agreeableness is associated with the *caregiving system* and may have evolved to facilitate bonding with mates and caring for offspring; Conscientiousness is associated with the *self-regulation system*, and may have evolved to facilitate conforming to social standards and being disciplined, persistent, and task oriented; Neuroticism is associated with the *avoidance system* and may have evolved to facilitate avoiding danger; and Openness is associated with the *exploratory system*, and may have evolved to facilitate exploring the environment, learning novel skills, and innovating.

The development of the Big Five taxonomy revolutionized personality research by providing an overarching organizational framework into which most, if not all, traits can be classified (Bainbridge et al., 2022; John, 2021).[5] The Big Five domains provide a coherent organizing system not only for traits but also for socioemotional skills (Soto et al., 2024) and psychiatric disorders (Widiger et al., 2019), including personality disorders (Clark & Watson, 2022). The Big Five thus provide an efficient system for synthesizing research findings for a wide range of individual-difference constructs, which can be seen most clearly in the numerous meta-analyses of how personality develops over time and relates to important life outcomes (see later sections on personality development and the real-world consequences of personality).

Research over the past decade has focused on explicating the Big Five taxonomy at multiple hierarchical levels. Just as the Linnaean taxonomy includes broad categories such as “animals” that can subdivided into increasingly more specific categories (e.g., mammals, primates, gorillas), each Big Five domain can be subdivided into more specific categories, including personality *aspects* (DeYoung et al., 2007), which are nested within the Big Five domains; *facets* (Soto & John, 2017), which are nested within aspects; and *nuances* (Mõttus et al., 2017), which are nested within facets. For example, the widely used Big Five Inventory-2 (Soto & John, 2017) includes three facet scales for each Big Five domain, including Compassion, Respectfulness, and Trust for the Agreeableness

domain, and Intellectual Curiosity, Aesthetic Sensitivity, and Creative Imagination for the Openness domain. However, the exact number and nature of these more specific levels of the personality trait taxonomy (i.e., aspects, facets, nuances) remains open to debate.

In contrast, there is less debate about the superordinate or "meta-traits" that exist at a broader level than the Big Five domains. The two meta-traits are referred to as Plasticity (which captures the shared variance of Extraversion and Openness) and Stability (which captures the shared variance of Agreeableness, Conscientiousness, and Neuroticism) (DeYoung, 2006; Digman, 1997). Plasticity reflects exploratory functions such as agentic action and other tendencies required to innovate and flexibly adapt to a changing environment, whereas Stability reflects the self-regulatory capacities needed to pursue long-term goals, manage emotions, and get along with other people (DeYoung, 2015). Although the self-regulatory system has the strongest conceptual association with Conscientiousness (as noted earlier), this system is also associated empirically with Agreeableness and Neuroticism.

Recent research on the hierarchical structure of personality suggests that more specific personality units (e.g., facets and nuances) often predict outcomes above and beyond the broader Big Five domains (Stewart et al., 2022). Moreover, distinct developmental processes unfold at different levels of the hierarchy. For example, Ringwald et al. (2024) found that youth followed from adolescence into early adulthood displayed increasing levels of maturity at the domain level (increases in Agreeableness and Conscientiousness and decreases in Neuroticism), but in some cases this developmental trend toward maturity diverged at the facet level (e.g., the emotional volatility facet of Neuroticism decreased, but the anxiety facet increased).

Some researchers have questioned whether the Big Five domains truly capture all important individual differences among people. Ashton and Lee (2020), for example, believe that content related to being fair, modest, and sincere (vs. greedy and deceitful) is missing from the Big Five taxonomy and proposed that a sixth broad domain – Honesty-Humility – is needed. However, many researchers view Honesty-Humility as part of the Agreeableness domain, given the high correlation between measures of the two constructs (Lynam et al., 2020; Soto, 2020). Cutler and Condon (2023) used natural language processing (NLP) models to identify structural relations among words in large corpora of text and failed to find evidence for factors related to the Neuroticism and Openness domains, findings that they believe undermine the validity of the Big Five framework. However, the use of NLP models to uncover the structure of personality is still in its infancy, and the extent to which these models provide fundamental insights remains to be seen.

Researchers have also challenged the presumed universality of the Big Five framework. Etic approaches (i.e., evaluating the structure of personality across cultures using personality measures developed in the U.S. or some other Western culture) generally support the replicability of the Big Five structure across nations and language groups (John, 2021), but emic research (i.e., establishing indigenous factors using a bottom-up approach) has produced mixed results (e.g., Benet-Martinez & John, 2000; Cheung et al., 2011; Saucier & Goldberg, 2001). For example, Thalmayer et al. (2020; 2021) failed to find support for a Big Five structure in their lexical studies of personality structure in sub-Saharan Africa. Thus, more work is needed to identify boundary conditions on the generalizability of the Big Five domains.

Another important future direction is understanding the structure of personality traits at the *within-person level*. The Big Five domains represent the structure of *between-person* differences in personality, but how individual traits cluster together within a person over time is a separate issue. For example, we know that at the between-person level traits like compassion, respectfulness, and

trust are intercorrelated across people, but these same traits may not intercorrelate within a person over time and across situations. In fact, the evidence suggests that the within-person structure of personality traits often deviates from the Big Five structure and varies substantially across people (Beck & Jackson, 2020), despite being relatively stable over months to years (Beck & Jackson, 2022a; 2022b). Consequently, it is unlikely we will ever find a generalizable within-person structure of traits that would serve the same function as the Big Five domains. In summary, researchers have made considerable progress towards a consensual taxonomy of personality traits over the past few decades, but much work remains to be done.

Motives

The second level of personality structure – motives – includes what people desire for themselves, either consciously ("explicit motives") or unconsciously ("implicit motives"). Motives are thought to be elicited or activated by environmental stimuli, and consequently motives can be seen as adaptive ways to connect basic tendencies (i.e., personality traits) to the demands of one's situational context (McAdams & Pals, 2006). Personality psychology has a longstanding interest in motivation, and virtually all grand theories of personality unite personality and motivation within one framework (e.g., Bandura, 1986; Erikson, 1950; Freud, 1927; Jung, 1954; McClelland, 1961; Murray, 1938; Rogers, 1959). Many of these early theories emphasized a similar set of broad motives or needs (needs are assumed to drive motivation), including the need to maximize pleasant feelings and avoid negative feelings, the need to maintain a stable and coherent psychological system, the need for relatedness and connection, and the need to maintain and enhance self-esteem (Epstein, 2007).

However, the field failed to reach consensus on the nature and number of primary motivational systems and many alternative frameworks have been proposed. The most influential framework has been McClelland's (1961) three broad motives: *achievement* (the need to demonstrate high performance levels and attain high standards of excellence), *power* (the need to control and influence the behavior of others), and *affiliation* (the need to spend time with other people and to establish and maintain friendly relationships with others). McAdams (1989) extended this framework by proposing a fourth motivation domain, *intimacy* (the need for emotionally close and intimate relationships with others). Another personality theory, Socioanalytic Theory (Hogan & Blickle, 2018), postulates that people are motivated by three primary needs: social acceptance (getting along), social status (getting ahead), and finding personal meaning. More recent research (Wilkowski et al., 2020) examining the structure of personality motives identified four broad domains that have relatively little overlap with earlier taxonomies: Prominence (victory, power, image, prestige), Inclusiveness (empathy, diversity, philanthropy, friendship), Negativity-Prevention (avoiding distress, harassment, aggravation), and Tradition (religion, nation, family, pureness). Personal values also fall under the rubric of motivational units, and have some overlapping (e.g., achievement, power, tradition) and some more distinct (e.g., conformity, self-direction, benevolence, universalism) content domains (Schwartz, 1994; Schwart et al., 2012).

Personality researchers have also studied a wide range of more specific motivational constructs, including *life goals* ("have a high-status career"; Roberts & Robins, 2000), *personal strivings* ("make life easier for my family"; Emmons, 1986), and *personal projects* ("apply to graduate school"; Little, 1983), which focus on daily, proximal, and highly contextualized goals that guide individuals' behaviors in their current environment. These more specific motivational units can, to some extent, be classified into the four broad motives (achievement, power, affiliation, intimacy) or the three

needs of Socioanalytic Theory (getting along, getting ahead, and finding meaning), but none of these theoretical models provides the kind of consensual and comprehensive framework that the Big Five provides for traits. Thus, the research literature on motivation has a long way to go before it has a widely accepted taxonomy of motives.

Narrative Identity

The final, and most idiographic (i.e., unique to each individual), level of personality is narrative identity. Narrative identity is a person's internalized and evolving story of how they came to be the person they are, and are becoming, based on their reconstruction of the past and anticipation of an imagined future (McAdams, 2021). Narrative approaches to personality complement the more nomothetic approaches (i.e., broadly applicable to all people) that focus on dispositional traits and motivations (McAdams & Pals, 2006). Although a person's narratives may change over time, they provide temporal unity and a sense of overarching purpose throughout one's life. Personal narratives share similarities with fictional stories, including specific scenes with a temporal sequence, ideological settings, and recurrent thematic lines. Research investigating the structure and content of narrative identity has identified common domains across life stories, including motivational and affective themes (e.g., redemption, agency, communion), autobiographical reasoning (e.g., thematic coherence, exploratory processing, meaning-making, growth), and structural similarities (e.g., factors, context, and chronological coherence) (McLean et al., 2020).

Although narrative measures tap into quite different psychological processes than trait measures, researchers have found theoretically meaningful associations between narrative constructs and the Big Five (Bühler et al., 2021; Dunlop et al., 2020; Guo et al., 2016; Lodi-Smith et al., 2009), including specific personality units such as Big Five aspects (Chou et al., 2024). For example, people whose self-narratives include redemptive themes (transforming negative events into positive experiences) tend to be less neurotic and more agreeable and conscientious (Guo et al., 2016). A longitudinal study of self-narratives and personality change found that college students who were more conscientious, open to new experiences, and extraverted when they began college, and who increased over time in conscientiousness and decreased in neuroticism, provided narratives at the end of college that were more exploratory and higher in positive affect; these two forms of narrative processing were associated with increases in psychological adjustment independent of the effects of personality trait change (Lodi-Smith et al., 2009).

All three levels of personality structure (traits, motives, narrative identity) influence how people interpret and react to situations and attend to specific aspects of their environments. Although the Big Five taxonomy has dominated personality research and provides an efficient method for describing how people differ from each other, the Big Five are just part of a complete picture of what encompasses personality. In addition to motives and narrative identity, many other individual-difference variables are considered part of personality, including numerous variables studied in both personality and social psychology, such as self-esteem, narcissism, optimism, life satisfaction, right-wing authoritarianism, moral values, attachment style, and many others.

McAdams (2016; 2020) provides a compelling example of how all three personality units (traits, motives, narratives) can be leveraged to more fully understand one of the most provocative and polarizing personalities in U.S. history, President Donald Trump. Drawing on extensive historical research and analysis, McAdams characterizes Trump as having sky-high Extraversion and off-the-chart low Agreeableness; motivational goals organized around a narcissistic need for attention and admiration; and a personal narrative (to the extent he has any coherent internal story) of a *warrior*,

viewing life as "a series of battles ending in victory or defeat." McAdams' holistic evidence-based approach leads to important insights into Trump's hostile outbursts and self-sabotaging behaviors, and helps explain why Trump elicits avid and unwavering support from his followers and contempt and derision from his detractors. Viewing President Trump solely through a trait lens – as a disagreeable extravert – would miss the big picture of how and why he behaves the way he does.[6]

How Can We Best Measure Individual Differences In Personality?

Personality psychology has a long tradition of methodological rigor, and assessment is widely viewed as foundational to the research process. It is not hyperbole to state that personality psychologists are obsessed with measurement issues and the construct validity of personality tests. There is a reason for this: measuring personality is difficult! Fortunately, personality researchers have spent decades developing measures that are reliable and valid across multiple populations and contexts. The *Handbook of Research Methods in Personality Psychology* (Beck & Robins, in press; Robins et al., 2007) describes the diversity of measures used by personality researchers, including self-report personality tests, informant reports, observational assessments of behavior, experience sampling methods (ESM), narrative approaches, mobile sensing, performance on cognitive-behavioral tasks, structured interviews, and a variety of physiological measures (e.g., hormones, neural function assessed via fMRI, genetic sequencing). Table 2 shows 17 measures ranked by their frequency of use by personality researchers (Robins et al., 2007). In this section, we review four of the most commonly used measures – self-report tests, informant reports, behavioral measures, and narrative assessments – and then discuss current debates about which assessment method is best and how to address jingle-jangle problems in the conceptualization and measurement of personality constructs.

Table 2: **The Methodological Toolkit of the Personality Psychologist**

Method	Mean (SD)	% ever used[a]
Assessment methods		
Self-report scales and questionnaires	6.17 (0.93)	100%
Judgments of self and others	5.07 (1.57)	99%
Informant reports	3.68 (1.82)	86%
Behavioral observation	3.58 (1.47)	89%
Structured interviews	3.15 (1.89)	76%
Behavioral responses	3.11 (1.55)	81%
Other judgment tasks (e.g., of stimuli)	3.10 (1.61)	79%
Narrative/open-ended questionnaires	3.03 (1.69)	74%
Reaction time measures	2.93 (1.90)	61%
Experience sampling measures	2.89 (1.90)	65%
Implicit measures	2.76 (1.87)	64%
Memory tasks	2.52 (1.58)	62%
Autonomic arousal	2.22 (1.42)	57%
Judgments of groups/nations/cultures	2.19 (1.68)	43%
Hormone levels	1.94 (1.59)	36%
Neuroimaging (fMRI, ERP, etc.)	1.75 (1.44)	32%
Molecular genetics/DNA testing	1.60 (1.21)	26%
Research designs		
Correlational	5.76 (1.03)	100%
Longitudinal	4.10 (1.59)	93%
Cross-sectional	4.03 (1.50)	96%
Experimental	3.76 (1.80)	86%
Quasi-experimental	3.60 (1.75)	86%
Field studies	3.44 (1.73)	83%
Cross-cultural	2.86 (1.51)	76%
Dyadic or group interactions	2.82 (1.61)	71%
Patient studies	2.36 (1.56)	58%
Twin and adoption studies	1.69 (1.49)	22%
Psychobiography/case studies	1.42 (1.14)	18%
Cross-species	1.33 (1.10)	10%

Note: N = 72. Participants were asked to rate how frequently they used 17 assessment methods and 12 research designs in their research. Ratings were made on a 7-point scale, ranging from 1 (never) to 7 (always), with 4 (sometimes) as the midpoint of the scale. Adapted from Robins, Tracy, and Sherman (2007). [a] *Percentage of respondents who indicated that they ever used the method in their research (i.e., who gave any rating other than 1, "never").*

Self-Report Personality Tests

Self-report tests are the most commonly used assessment method in personality research. Widely used personality tests include the Big Five Inventory-2 (BFI-2; Soto & John, 2017), the NEO-PI-R (Costa & McCrae, 1992), the International Personality Item Pool (IPIP; Goldberg et al., 2006), and the HEXACO (Lee & Ashton, 2018), but there are numerous other well-validated measures of personality traits.[7] Self-report measures have a number of advantages, most notably that individuals have access to their own thoughts, feelings, and behaviors in all contexts and every period of their lives. Although close others may witness our behaviors in a wide range of circumstances, they may know little about our internal thoughts and feelings in these contexts. Therefore, the self has more information than other informants and unique access to information about one's own personality. Self-report data are also efficient to collect. However, individuals might exhibit a positivity bias when reporting on their personality or lack insight into their actual

personality tendencies. These limitations have sometimes been construed as fatal flaws of self-report measures, but there is substantial evidence that this concern is exaggerated – most of the time and for most aspects of personality, people can and do report reliably and validly about their own personalities (Paulhus & Vazire, 2007; Robins & John, 1997). Even narcissistic individuals, for whom self-deception is a defining feature, provide accurate self-reports about their narcissistic tendencies, and acknowledge that others view them as narcissistic (Carlson et al., 2011; Carlson, 2013). Further supporting their validity, personality tests predict a wide range of important outcomes (see the section on real-world implications of personality). Moreover, many large companies use self-report personality tests to select employees, and these companies are legally required to demonstrate the predictive validity of these tests.

Informant Reports

In the 4th century BCE, Theophrastus wrote vivid personality descriptions of 30 different character types (e.g., The Flatterer, The Reckless Man, The Grumbler) that he encountered in his daily life. More than two millennia later, we now know that Theophrastus's personality assessments were likely to be reasonably accurate depictions of his fellow Athenians. Informants who know the target well (e.g., a friend, parent, spouse/partner, or teacher) provide reliable and valid assessments of personality traits (e.g., Funder, 2012; Letzring et al., 2021; Vazire, 2006; Zola et al., 2021). When informants are well-acquainted with the target, they have considerable exposure to the target's thoughts, feelings, and behaviors over time and across contexts, and consequently, a strong evidentiary basis on which to make inferences about personality. In one study, personality assessments by close friends when participants were age 21 predicted how long the participants lived when mortality records were examined 75 years later (Jackson et al., 2015). Specifically, men rated by their peers as more *conscientious* and *open to new experiences* lived longer, whereas women rated as more *emotionally stable* and *agreeable* lived longer; these findings may reflect the prevalence of traditional gender roles when the participants were growing up.

In general, reports by informants tend to show moderate levels of agreement with each other and with self-reports, although the level of agreement varies across different types of informants (e.g., friend vs. spouse) and different traits (Connelly & Ones, 2010; Robins & John, 1997; Zola et al., 2021). Surprisingly, how well-acquainted informants are with the target does not seem to affect the level of agreement among informants or self-other agreement (e.g., Biesanz et al., 2007; Kenny, 2004). Even more surprising, self and informant reports do not differ in how positive they are; that is, meta-analytic data show that people do not, on average, see themselves more positively than others see them (Kim et al., 2019), contrary to the widely discussed self-enhancement effect.

Informant reports are relatively quick and easy to obtain and have two additional advantages (Vazire, 2006). First, they provide an ideal complement to self-reports because self-reports reflect an inside (i.e., identity) perspective on personality, whereas informant reports provide an outside (i.e., reputation; Hogan, 1998) perspective. Second, self-reports are necessarily limited to a single person, whereas informant reports can be aggregated across multiple raters to obtain a more reliable assessment—this is particularly helpful because the biases of different informants may cancel out in the aggregate (Hofstee, 1994). These advantages demonstrate that a composite of multiple informants, or a composite of self and informant reports, may provide a more complete and valid picture of a person's personality than any single judgment. Combining self and informant reports is relatively common in personality research. For example, in research using data from our longitudinal study of Mexican-origin families, the California Families Project, we generally assess

temperament traits by compositing child self-report with parent reports on the child's traits (e.g., Atherton et al., 2020; Cheng et al., 2024; Lawson et al., 2023). In summary, research suggests that self- and informant reports of personality are reliable, valid, and complementary methods for assessing personality.

Behavioral Measures And Cognitive Tasks

Personality researchers have developed or adapted numerous behavioral measures, from lab tasks measuring brief snippets of behavior in response to highly controlled stimuli to everyday behaviors in real-world contexts. Behavioral measures obtained in structured contexts include (but are not limited to): cognitive task-based measures of self-regulation (e.g., Eisenberg et al., 2019); IAT-based measures of the Big Five (Back et al., 2009; Schnabel et al., 2006), shyness (Asendorpf et al., 2002), and self-esteem (Karpinski, 2004); choice experiments used by behavioral economists to assess risk taking and related constructs (Becker et al., 2012; Borghans et al., 2008; Falk et al., 2023); simulation tasks such as the Balloon Analog Risk Task (Lejuez et al., 2003) and the Stoplight Task (Chein et al., 2011) to assess impulsivity and risky decision making; and non-computer based behavioral measures such as the delay of gratification task (Mischel et al., 1972). More recently, there is an emerging movement to develop game-based measures of personality in which participants' reactions to various images, scenarios, or storylines are validated as measures of different personality traits (Hilliard et al., 2022; McCord et al., 2019; Ramos-Villagrasa et al., 2022; Wu et al., 2022); game-based personality assessments are increasingly used by tech companies and in other real-world contexts (e.g., KnackApp; Skillprint). Finally, although less common (Baumeister et al., 2007), personality researchers sometimes code personality-relevant behavior from semi-structured lab tasks, such as getting acquainted interactions, telling stories or jokes, playing charades or twister, describing multiple uses of a brick using only pantomime, and other similar situational tasks (Borkenau et al., 2001; Furr & Funder, 2006; Jayawickreme et al., 2023). Supporting the validity of these approaches, when neutral observers code behavior in these tasks, they tend to agree with each other, and with the participants' self-reports, about how participants behaved in each situation and how their behavior changed across situations (Jayawickreme et al., 2023).

In addition to lab-based tasks, personality researchers assess real-world behaviors relevant to personality dispositions. Most notably, research using experience sampling methods (ESM) and ecological momentary assessments (EMA) examine *in situ* (in the moment) reports of what people are doing, thinking, and feeling, including measures of personality "states," which are assumed to be momentary expressions of underlying traits (e.g., Matz & Harari, 2021; Ringwald et al., 2022). Another method for assessing people in their day-to-day lives is the Electronically Activated Recorder (EAR), which turns on at random or prespecified intervals throughout the day and records all sounds (e.g., words spoken, environmental noises) in a person's environment (e.g., Sun et al., 2020). These sound snippets can then be transcribed and coded as indicative of specific traits; for example, frequency of laughing is a behavioral indicator of Extraversion. ESM, EMA, and EAR data all provide insight into within-person dynamics—how the expression of personality fluctuates over time in response to interaction partners and situational contexts. Consequently, these methods provide a more idiographic perspective on personality because they allow researchers to study personality dynamics unique to each person (Beck & Jackson, 2020; 2021).

Another approach to assessing personality in real-world contexts is to infer personality traits from people's physical environments (e.g., their dorm room or office). These environments are presumed to provide clues about past behaviors (e.g., tidying up one's room, attending concerts, and hanging

posters on one's wall), referred to as "behavioral residue." In one study, Gosling et al. (2002) found that individuals higher in Conscientiousness tend to have more organized living spaces, and individuals higher in Openness tend to have more books in their rooms.

Finally, although not strictly considered behavioral measures, personality researchers have increasingly mined digital records and institutional records (criminal, school, work, hospital, etc.), which are presumed to reflect the residue of a person's behavior over months, years, or even decades. For example, a person's social media activity (on platforms like Facebook, X, Instagram, and TikTok) can be mined (e.g., using machine learning and large language models) to assess personality (Bleidorn & Hopwood, 2019; Giorgi et al., 2022; Harari et al., 2020; Osterholz et al., 2023; Stachl et al., 2020), and their location can be geocoded to determine how often they are at a bar (high extraversion) or a museum (high openness) (Müller et al., 2022). (Interestingly, there is also an emerging movement to assess the "personality" of AIs such as ChatGPT; Pellert et al., 2024.) More generally, mobile sensing technologies (e.g., using smartphones) allow researchers to collect data about "people's thoughts, feelings, and behaviors in an ecologically sensitive manner, longitudinally, across situational contexts, and at scale" (Harari et al., 2020, p. 649; Mehl et al., 2023). Institutional records, including court records of criminal convictions, school records of truancies and disciplinary actions, employment records of misconduct, and health records of disease and mortality, reflect even longer-term behavioral residue and can provide important information about a life lived in a reckless, irresponsible, and antisocial way, and thus may be diagnostic of low conscientiousness.

Narrative Assessments

Like life records, narrative assessments view personality through a long-term lens. However, whereas life records reflect objective outcomes in a person's life, narrative identity reflects the subjective, internal construal of how one's life is playing out—not (necessarily) what actually happened, but rather the story people tell themselves when they narrate their lives. To assess narrative identity, researchers typically ask participants to describe and interpret important events in their lives (e.g., turning points, low points, etc.) using an open-ended response format. The resulting narratives are then coded using validated coding systems to assess individual differences in the stories people tell about themselves (Adler et al., 2017). These coding systems focus on constructs such as positive and negative emotional tone, motivation (agency, communion), redemption themes (i.e., negative beginning followed by a positive ending), contamination themes (i.e., positive beginning followed by a negative ending), and autobiographical reasoning (thematic coherence, exploratory processing, meaning making) (Dunlop et al., 2020; McLean et al., 2020). Although more idiographic than other forms of personality assessment, narrative identity assessments nonetheless predict important life outcomes (e.g., health, life satisfaction, well-being) and are associated in theoretically meaningful ways with self-report personality tests (e.g., Adler et al., 2016; Dunlop & Tracy, 2013, Lodi-Smith et al., 2009; McAdams et al., 2001; Raggatt, 2006).

Which Assessment Method Is Best?

After learning about the plethora of approaches to assessing personality, readers may wonder—which assessment method is best? It's a reasonable question, but difficult to answer. In general, personality psychologists do not view any particular measure as the "gold standard." Instead, all of the primary approaches to assessing personality are seen as valid but flawed, with each providing partially overlapping but also partially unique information about a person.[8] Consequently,

personality researchers frequently advocate for (and occasionally implement) a multi-method approach to personality assessment, which has a long history in the field (Craik, 1986). For example, in our 20-year longitudinal study, the California Families Project, we are interested in how self-regulatory traits develop over time and predict successful life outcomes. Because we do not believe there is a gold standard measure of self-regulation, we assessed the construct (broadly conceptualized) in a variety of ways, including self-report and informant (parent) report measures of Effortful Control and Conscientiousness; cognitive-behavioral tasks (GoNoGo measure of response inhibition; flanker measure of inhibitory control); behavior coded in structured parent-child interactions; fMRI assessments of neural activity in cognitive control regions; and life outcome data related to poor self-regulation (e.g., school records of classroom disciplinary problems). Together, these measures provide a multi-method assessment of self-regulation that we believe is superior to any single, individual measure.

However, there are two caveats to this perspective: sometimes different methods actually assess different constructs, and some proposed measures of stable individual differences are not psychometrically sound. For example, self-report scales and behavioral task-based measures of self-regulation were long assumed to measure the same construct: individual differences in the ability to regulate impulses and inhibit a dominant response in the service of long-term goals. However, self-report and task-based measures actually assess "separate constructs" (Enkavi et al., 2019, p. 24398) and capture distinct processes (Friedman & Banich, 2019; Malanchini et al., 2019). Specifically, task-based measures tap responses in a specific structured situation and reflect maximal self-regulatory performance, whereas self-reports assess behavioral tendencies across a wide range of unstructured situations and reflect typical self-regulatory capacity (Dang et al., 2020).

Moreover, one could make the case that from a personality perspective—where the emphasis is on measuring *stable* individual differences in a person's capacity to self-regulate *across contexts*—self-report personality tests are not just different but also preferable to behavioral tasks. Self-report measures of self-regulation have (1) substantially higher test-retest reliability (Enkavi et al., 2019; Kadlec et al., 2023), a basic criterion for measuring trait-like individual differences; (2) better convergent validity, that is, different self-report measures of self-regulation are moderately intercorrelated whereas different task-based measures of self-regulation are weekly intercorrelated (Duckworth & Kerns, 2011; Gärtner & Strobel, 2021); and (3) better predictive validity than task-based measures (Eisenberg et al., 2019). Thus, if the goal is to assess self-regulation as a stable trait, rather than in-the-moment self-regulatory responses to a specific experimental context, then self-report personality tests are more reliable and valid than behavioral tasks. Whether the same conclusion holds for self-report and task-based measures of other personality traits has yet to be determined. This example highlights a more general take-home message: Because there is no single gold standard measure of complex psychological traits, different methods of assessing personality are expected (and indeed likely) to produce at least somewhat discrepant results. However, this does not absolve researchers of the responsibility to demonstrate that ostensible measures of the same construct show some minimal level of convergence with each other and that all assessment methods demonstrate adequate reliability and validity.

The Jingle-Jangle Jungle

Personality psychologists devote a great deal of effort to establishing the construct validity of their measures, but the field nonetheless suffers from jingle-jangle problems. *Jingle* occurs when two constructs or measures are distinct but named the same (Thorndike, 1904), whereas *jangle* occurs

when two constructs or measures are identical, yet named differently (Kelley, 1927). The Big Five taxonomy was developed, in part, to deal with jingle-jangle issues because it serves as an organizing framework for all, or nearly all, measures of personality traits, and thus provides a way to determine which trait measures are part of the same conceptual domain and which are not (regardless of how the scale is labeled) (Bainbridge et al., 2022; John, 2021), thereby holding researchers accountable when they attempt to introduce a "new" construct to the field. Even individual-difference measures that are not considered traditional trait measures, but are often studied by social-personality psychologists, can be classified within the Big Five framework (Bainbridge et al., 2022). For example, when the construct of grit was first proposed (Duckworth et al., 2007), many researchers wondered how grit differed from Conscientiousness (i.e., if they were jangled); after a decade of research, it became clear that grit should be considered a facet of Conscientiousness rather than a novel personality construct (Credé et al., 2017).

Demonstrating that two potentially jingled or jangled measures are, or are not, empirically related to the same Big Five domain is a helpful but relatively crude way to address jingle-jangle problems. Lawson and Robins (2021) recently developed a more comprehensive and nuanced framework for understanding "sibling" constructs, that is, constructs that have conceptual and/or empirical overlap but are not identical. Such sibling relationships can be better understood by examining the extent to which the constructs: (1) are defined in a conceptually similar way; (2) overlap in their *theorized* nomological networks; (3) overlap in their *observed* nomological networks; (4) correlate strongly with each other; (5) have measures that together form a strong general factor; (6) have measures that show little incremental validity over each other; (7) follow similar developmental trajectories; (8) are caused by the same situational, environmental, and genetic factors; (9) are causally related to each other; and (10) are state/trait manifestations of the same underlying process. These procedures allow researchers to pinpoint precisely how potential sibling constructs are interconnected (conceptually and empirically) and help identify when a purportedly new construct is simply a relabeling of an existing construct.

What Are The Developmental Origins Of Personality And How Does Personality Change Across The Lifespan?

Research on personality development focuses on the age at which individual variability in personality first emerges, the role of nature (genes) and nurture (environment) in shaping personality, patterns of consistency and change in personality across the lifespan, and whether people can volitionally change their personality. Of all the areas of personality research, personality development has experienced the sharpest increase in attention in recent years (Roberts & Yoon, 2022). Indeed, in the previous edition of *The Handbook of Social Psychology*, the chapter on personality included only a few sentences about personality development (Funder & Fast, 2010). The dramatic increase in research on personality development has been driven, at least in part, by the widespread availability of numerous long-term longitudinal studies of personality (Personality Development Collaborative, 2024).

When Does Personality First Emerge?

McAdams (2013; 2021) provided a model of the emergence of individual differences in personality from childhood to early adulthood that parallels the three-tiered framework of traits, motives, and narrative identity. Early in development, young children are *actors* who show relatively stable

individual differences (i.e., traits) in how they interact with strangers, form bonds with caregivers, explore and manipulate their environment, regulate their needs, respond to reinforcements and other environmental contingencies, and express their distress. By middle childhood, children are motivated *agents* with the cognitive, affective, and self-regulatory skills to shape their lives and pursue goals (Shiner, 2021). In adolescence and early adulthood, youth are *authors* who narrate their own stories by linking past, present, and future.

With regard to early emerging traits, young children show relatively stable individual differences that can be organized into three broad domains: Positive Emotionality or Surgency (i.e., pleasure derived from high intensity or novel activities), Negative Emotionality (i.e., distress, frustration, fear, sadness, and hostile reactions to negative stimuli), and Effortful Control (i.e., the capacity to plan and suppress inappropriate impulses, perform an action or pursue goals when there are competing desires, and focus and shift attention when needed) (Rothbart, 2007; Rothbart, 2011). These three "temperament" domains are assumed to provide the foundation for adult personality traits. Specifically, children with high levels of Positive Emotionality/Surgency are assumed to develop into adults with high levels of Extraversion, children with high levels of Negative Emotionality develop into adults with high Neuroticism, and children with high levels of Effortful Control develop into adults with high Conscientiousness (Ringwald et al., 2025). It is not clear at what point in development personality differentiates from the three temperament domains into the Big Five structure, but studies with children that use Big Five measures often find evidence for the two "missing" domains, Agreeableness and Openness, suggesting that the three-dimensional structure of temperament might be an artifact of the lack of content (i.e., relevant items) related to these two domains on child and adolescent temperament scales (Shiner et al., 2021).

The Role Of Genes And Environment

Decades of research have demonstrated that all personality traits are influenced by genetic factors. Numerous twin and adoption studies, often with large representative samples, have shown that genetic influences account for about half of the variation in self-reported, informant-reported, and behaviorally coded personality traits (Krueger & Johnson, 2021). In fact, identical twins separated at birth tend to grow up having quite similar personality traits, despite being raised by different parents in different home environments (e.g., Bouchard et al., 1990). This finding directly contradicts the strict behaviorist view that individuals are entirely a product of their environments (Watson, 1958), and instead supports the view that personality differences are rooted in biologically-based tendencies that have been shaped by evolution.

An important caveat is that *half* of the variation indeed means half of the variation, which leaves the other half of personality differences explained by environmental factors. But which environmental factors? Researchers studying the genetics of personality partition environmental factors into two broad categories: shared and nonshared. One of the most shocking findings, which has been repeatedly replicated, is that shared environmental influences (experiences that siblings growing up in the same family have in common) account for almost no variation in personality. In contrast, non-shared environmental influences (experiences not shared with siblings, such as unique relationships with peers and teachers, idiosyncratic experiences in the family environment, and physical and mental health problems) account for the bulk of the remaining 50% beyond genetics. This means that parenting behaviors have little or no effect on how their child's personality develops, except to the extent that parents treat one sibling differently than another (Plomin, 2018). More generally, it means that two genetically related siblings who were separated at

birth and raised in *different* families are likely to have more similar personalities than genetically unrelated siblings who grew up in the *same* family.

When evaluating this research, several complexities and caveats should be considered (Plomin, 2018). First, there is no one-to-one correspondence between a person's genetic make-up and their personality; personality develops through complex interactions between multiple genetic factors and countless environmental experiences. Second, genetic and environmental influences should not be considered independent influences on personality. People select, modify, and construe their environment in part based on their genetic propensities. For example, children who have trouble with impulse control evoke harsher parenting than those with better self-control and are more likely to associate with deviant peers. This means that, in some cases, what seems like an environmental effect on personality development (e.g., growing up with a harsh parent, associating with deviant peers) may actually be driven by nature, not nurture. Third, although a person's genotype is fixed, gene expression can be modified by the environment, with certain environments turning genes "on" or "off" through epigenetic processes (e.g., Raffington et al., 2021). Finally, the idea that each trait might be related to a particular gene has long since been dismissed. Instead, personality phenotypes (i.e., traits) are influenced by thousands or even millions of genetic variants and the complex ways these variants interact with each other and the environment. These examples highlight the simplicity of the nature-nurture debate and suggest that the critical question is not which is more important, but rather *how* nature and nurture work together to shape personality development.

Consistency And Change Across The Lifespan

Numerous large-scale longitudinal studies and meta-analyses support several conclusions about personality consistency and change (Bleidorn et al., 2021; Bleidorn et al., 2022). First, virtually all personality traits are moderately stable over time, with test-retest correlations around .40 to .60 across relatively long periods of time (e.g., 5 to 10 years). Moreover, personality tends to become more stable as people go through childhood and enter young adulthood. These findings are noteworthy because they confirm that personality traits are relatively enduring characteristics by the time a person reaches adulthood. In other words, individuals who are shyer than their peers at age 20 are likely to remain shyer than their peers at age 30. Personality stability is assumed to increase with age (known as the *cumulative continuity principle*) because adulthood is a time when maturational (biologically based) changes subside, social roles stabilize, environmental contexts are increasingly subject to individual control, and individuals have a more stable sense of self and identity. At the same time, there is never a period in the lifespan when personality ceases to change, contradicting William James' assertion that personality is "set like plaster" by age 30. Indeed, the longer individuals are followed over time, the less their personality maintains the same relative levels compared to others; across 50 years, the average rank-order stability (test-retest correlation) of personality was .31 (corrected for measurement error; Damian et al., 2019).

Second, on average, people become more conscientious, agreeable, and emotionally stable as they go through life—in other words, they become more mature. These changes, referred to as the *maturity principle* of personality development, tend to reflect increases in personality characteristics that help individuals meet the demands of adult social roles as employees, committed romantic partners, and parents. However, the gradual shift toward increasing levels of personality maturity is interrupted during adolescence, when a temporary dip in interpersonally relevant traits such as conscientiousness, agreeableness, and extraversion seems to occur (Atherton et al., 2020; Denissen

et al., 2013; Soto & Tackett, 2015). Moreover, there is emerging evidence that the normative trend toward personality maturation reverses during old age, when conscientiousness, agreeableness, emotional stability, and extraversion may decline (Atherton et al., 2022; Graham et al., 2020; Seifert et al., 2024). All of these average changes in personality, although well-documented and replicable, tend to be small and gradual when viewed from year to year. Over decades of life, however, age-related personality changes in a population can be quite substantial.

Third, people differ in the way their personality changes, often deviating substantially from average trends (Graham et al., 2020; Schwaba & Bleidorn, 2018). For example, although most individuals increase in conscientiousness during the transition into young adulthood, some individuals show no changes during this transition or even decline in conscientiousness (e.g., Ringwald et al., 2024). A large body of research has explored some of the reasons underlying these individual differences in personality change, often examining individual psychological factors all the way up to sociocultural factors (e.g., Atherton et al., 2020). Some studies have investigated how school and work behaviors and motivations impact personality development. For example, children who exert more effort on homework increase in conscientiousness (Göllner et al., 2017) and adults who are more invested in their work also increase in conscientiousness (Hudson et al., 2012). Social and relationship experiences are also related to subsequent changes in personality. For example, beginning a serious romantic relationship and having satisfying relationship experiences are associated with becoming less neurotic and more conscientious (Mund et al., 2016; Neyer & Lehnart, 2007; Robins et al., 2002; Wagner et al., 2015). In addition to personal life experiences, personality change can also occur as a result of collective experiences, such as the COVID-19 pandemic, which led to slight declines in extraversion, agreeableness, conscientiousness, and openness (e.g., Sutin et al., 2022). Together, these findings support the *plasticity principle*, which states that personality traits are open systems that can be influenced by the environment at any age (e.g., Roberts & Nichol, 2021).

An important caveat is that life events, including seemingly powerful experiences such as the birth of a child or the death of a spouse, tend to have surprisingly modest effects on personality change, and not only for personality traits but also for self-esteem and even life satisfaction (Bühler et al., 2024). However, rather than interpreting these findings as evidence that life events have a minimal impact on personality, a more apt conclusion is that people react differently to the same life event (Haehner et al., 2024; Schwaba, Denissen, et al., 2023) and do not all change in the same way (Schwaba & Bleidorn, 2018).[9] Thus, more research is needed to understand the factors that moderate the effects of significant life events on personality change.

Fourth, in addition to personality changes occurring passively as people age and in response to significant life events, personality can also change through volitional effort when people are motivated to improve aspects of their personality. This can occur through both clinical and non-clinical interventions. In clinical contexts, a large-scale meta-analysis found relatively enduring changes in personality, especially decreases in neuroticism, through various forms of therapy (Roberts et al., 2017). In nonclinical contexts, a smartphone-based app called PEACH (PErsonality coACH) uses various micro-interventions – implementing if-then intentions, performing novel behaviors and activities, and engaging in self-reflection to learn from successes and failures – to change targeted personality traits (Stieger et al., 2018). The PEACH app has been shown to increase extraversion, agreeableness, conscientiousness, and emotional stability (Stieger et al., 2021), as well as satisfaction in multiple life domains (Olaru et al., 2023). In a school-based randomized control trial, an intervention that targeted dysfunctional personality traits (e.g., impulsivity, sensation seeking, and anxiety sensitivity) led to reductions in overall levels of psychopathology in a large

sample of adolescent students (Lynch et al., 2023). A mega-analysis of dozens of intensive longitudinal studies showed that personality change can occur when people adopt goals to improve aspects of their personality and actively engage in tasks and challenges that push their behavior toward desired trait levels (Hudson et al., 2020). Together, these findings support the idea that personality change can occur when the behavioral, emotional, and cognitive manifestations of a particular trait are repeated frequently enough to become automatized habits that generalize to a broader range of situations, which then lead to changes in the underlying trait (Jackson & Wright, 2024; Quintus et al., 2021; Wrzus & Roberts, 2017).

In addition to behavioral interventions, personality may also be modifiable via psychopharmacological interventions, such as antidepressants and anti-anxiety medications to lower Neuroticism, oxytocin boosters and MDMA (ecstasy) to increase Agreeableness, and psilocybin to increase Openness. Decades from now, it may even be possible to change personality using gene-editing techniques like CRISPR, which could be used to alter the genes associated with a particular personality trait (assuming we eventually identify these genes). Of course, gene editing for personality change raises complex ethical questions.

Overall, the evidence suggests that people can, and often do, change their personality in meaningful ways that align with their personal goals. As Jarrett (2022) noted, "your inherited traits are like factory settings: yes, they incline you to act in a certain way in life, but with effort, commitment, and the right strategies, they can certainly be changed" (p. 127).

In summary, research on personality development indicates that both intrinsic biological factors and external life experiences shape personality. As people age, they show personality changes that indicate increasing levels of psychological maturity and an increasing capacity to fulfill important adult roles. Against this backdrop of normative changes toward maturity, individuals vary dramatically in the unique trajectory their constellation of personality traits follow. Personality becomes more stable with age but continues to change throughout the lifespan. Importantly, people can change their personality when they are motivated to do so. Together, these findings suggest that personality traits are dynamic constructs that show clear evidence of both stability and change, consistent with the idea that "personality traits are sufficiently broad and stable to predict a wide range of important life outcomes, but also malleable enough to potentially serve as powerful yet largely ignored targets for interventions" (Bleidorn et al., 2019, p. 4).

What Are The Processes That Lead To Individual Differences In Personality?

Researchers interested in personality processes study the biological, social-cognitive, self, social-contextual, and cultural processes that account for individual variability in personality. Researchers studying personality processes might examine, for example, the core thought patterns and emotional responses that characterize shy people, the biological factors (genes, hormones, neurotransmitters, neural activation patterns) that generate and account for those thought patterns and emotional responses, the situational and social-contextual factors that trigger shyness, and the cultural norms, values, and expectations that shape the experience and expression of shyness.

Biological Processes

Almost 90 years ago, Gordon Allport, widely considered the father of contemporary personality psychology, referred to personality traits as "neuropsychic structures" that were instantiated in "psychophysical systems" (Allport, 1937). This emphasis on the biological basis of human individuality has long been a part of the discipline of personality psychology. As a consequence, the kinds of destructive and polarizing debates about nature versus nurture that characterize other branches of psychology have rarely fomented in personality psychology. Allport (1937) himself noted that "no feature of personality is devoid of hereditary influences" (p. 105), and there has been comparatively little debate about this issue over the subsequent decades. It is safe to assume that Allport could not have envisioned the advances in neuroimaging and genetic analysis that have come to the forefront of psychological science. These technological advances provide researchers with an impressive and powerful set of tools for understanding the biological bases of human individuality.

Several strands of research accumulating over the past few decades provide strong evidence that personality differences are rooted in biological differences. First, non-human animals tend to show similar personality tendencies, providing an evolutionary thread connecting human and non-human animals that is almost certainly rooted in shared biological systems (Weiss, 2021).

Second, as noted previously, virtually all personality traits have a strong genetic basis, with little variability across traits in the strength of the genetic component; for example, the Big Five domains have approximately the same degree of heritability (Jang et al., 1996).[10] Nonetheless, genes are only an ingredient, not a solitary cause, of personality differences, with nonshared environmental factors playing an important role.

Third, people with brain damage often show substantial changes in their personality. The most prominent example is the case of Phineas Gage, a railroad worker who exhibited profound personality changes after a 3 ½ foot long iron rod penetrated his brain and came out the other side. After the accident, the previously conscientious and "well-balanced" Gage became impatient and impulsive, obstinate and capricious; Gage was no longer Gage, his friends and acquaintances noted (Harlow, 1868; O'Driscoll & Leach, 1998). Interestingly, brain damage can have positive as well as negative effects on personality. Jarrett (2022) recounts the story of a woman who suffered severe brain trauma after a bike accident; she told a journalist, "I think I've become a nicer person…I'm more patient and openly emotional, I've got a calmness that I never had before" (p. 56); in other words, she became more agreeable and less neurotic.

Fourth, fMRI studies have shown that personality differences are associated with distinct patterns of neural activity (DeYoung et al., 2021). Researchers have made the most progress toward identifying the neural systems that underlie Neuroticism/Negative Emotionality, Extraversion/Positive Emotionality, and Conscientiousness/Self-Regulation. The findings generally support the presumed biobehavioral system associated with these personality domains (see Table 1). Specifically, Neuroticism is associated with the biological system governing withdrawal/avoidance behavior, anxiety, and the detection of and response to threat (e.g., fight-flight-freeze), including the amygdala, and is linked to the neurotransmitter serotonin and the hormone cortisol. These tendencies towards avoidance, vigilance, and rumination contribute to the anxiety, stress, depression, irritability, and anger characteristic of high levels of neuroticism. Extraversion is associated with the biological system governing reward motivation and approach behavior, which is linked to the neurotransmitter dopamine. The well-replicated relation to the dopaminergic system explains why individuals high in extraversion find social interactions more rewarding and why they experience more positive emotions than individuals who are lower in extraversion.

Indeed, extraverted individuals have higher reward sensitivity to socializing, and socializing contributes to their greater well-being (Sun & Vazire, 2019). Conscientiousness, which involves paying attention without getting distracted, working effectively towards goals, and suppressing dysfunctional impulses, is associated with brain regions that are part of the ventral attention and goal priority networks.

However, the field is far from a comprehensive and coherent understanding of the neural bases of these personality domains, let alone other personality domains. For example, the neural basis of Openness depends on how the construct is operationalized and which facet is emphasized. Curiosity is related to the dopaminergic system, whereas the Intellect facet, which involves abstract thinking and critical reasoning, is associated with parts of the brain that are important for working memory and intelligence, like the frontoparietal network. The overall Openness domain is related to the default network responsible for imagination and other types of volitional thoughts. The neurobehavioral correlates of Agreeableness have often been studied using measures of empathy, which is associated with the default network, the insula, the neurotransmitter serotonin, and low levels of testosterone, but empathy is just one facet of the Agreeableness domain.

Some, perhaps many, personality psychologists remain dubious about the importance of studying the neurobiological correlates of personality traits, arguing for example, "We have literally wasted millions and millions of dollars pursuing underpowered, uninformative research out of some misplaced wish to find a biological root to our phenotypes" (Roberts & Yoon, 2022, p. 504). This skepticism seems warranted given recent research showing that previously observed associations between personality and structural measures of the brain (e.g., the size of particular brain regions) failed to replicate in large-scale studies (Avinun et al., 2020; Hyatt et al., 2022). Similar replicability problems have plagued research seeking to identify genetic variants associated with particular personality traits. To address this issue, a consortium of personality and genetics researchers is compiling extremely large data sets (over a million participants) to identify replicable genetic markers of personality traits (Schwaba et al., 2023).[11] We hope that neuroscience research on the brain mechanisms underlying personality will adopt similar collaborative approaches to increase the power of their research.

Finally, it is important to keep in mind that neither heritable traits nor the neural mechanisms that contribute to certain dispositions are immutable; both can be modified through experience. When people make positive changes in their everyday thoughts, feelings, and behaviors, they are modifying their brain's neural circuits and activation patterns—that is, they are shaping their brain to improve their personality. Similarly, as noted earlier, the environment can modify gene expression through epigenetic processes. Thus, although virtually all traits have a biological basis, the actual personality phenotype is expressed through complex interactions with the environment —interactions that are, to some extent, under our control.

Social-Cognitive Processes

Another active area of research focuses on cognitive processes underlying personality differences. Researchers in this tradition examine how beliefs, expectancies, goals, attributions, and other information-processing tendencies shape the way people perceive situations and their behavior in those situations. These processes can be modeled using attention, perception, priming, and cognitive control tasks (Robinson, 2021) and can explain why two people interpret the same objective event in dramatically different ways. Mischel's "cognitive-affective personality system" (CAPS) is a social-learning theory that conceptualizes personality as an individual's unique "If…

then" contingencies that describe how that person will act in different situations (Mischel & Shoda, 1995; Mischel, 1999). For example, according to the social-cognitive view of aggression, aggression-prone individuals show a "hostile attribution bias" and perceive ambiguous social cues as threatening and confrontative; as a result, in social interactions, they are more likely to feel that they have been insulted, maligned, attacked, or maltreated, even in situations that others might perceive as benign. Similarly, individuals high in Neuroticism, which is linked to the behavioral inhibition system, attend more to threatening stimuli, have a memory network that heightens negative affect, and show stronger punishment sensitivity, resulting in more frequent hostile attributions (Robinson, 2021). On the other hand, individuals higher in Agreeableness are more sensitive to positive, prosocial cues and better able to regulate their hostile thoughts, allowing these individuals to avoid outbursts of anger and aggression.

Dweck's (2021) cognitive-motivational theory of personality postulates that as people pursue a set of basic needs, they build mental representations of their experiences that help channel latent needs into active goals. Dweck refers to these mental representations as BEATs (Beliefs, Emotions, and Action Tendencies), and proposes that they provide scripts for engaging with the environment and selecting and pursuing need-fulfilling goals. These BEATs, and their underlying needs, serve as the foundation for recurrent and chronic tendencies to interact in characteristic ways, which generate the patterns of behavior that constitute personality traits. Thus, Dweck's theory views traits as the end product of a series of motivational and social-cognitive processes. Although Dweck does not deny that traits might have a biological basis, her theory, like most social-cognitive theories of personality, assumes that personality differences are primarily caused by differences in how people process and represent information about themselves, others, and the world. In this respect, social-cognitive accounts of personality differences are central to efforts to change personality—if personality reflects chronically accessible schemas, scripts, and stimulus-response tendencies learned through experience, then these same tendencies can be unlearned through alternative experiences.

Self Processes

A child gets a perfect score on her first spelling test and feels a sense of pride that motivates her to become even more hard working and conscientious at school. An adolescent looks in the mirror and sees acne forming and becomes more insecure and socially inhibited with peers. A politician lashes out at every perceived criticism in a desperate attempt to bolster his narcissistic self-image. An elderly adult experiencing memory loss begins to question her competence and gradually becomes timid and withdrawn in work and relationship contexts.

What unites these examples is that they all show how *self* processes – the way we perceive and evaluate ourselves – influence personality-relevant behaviors. Indeed, a complete understanding of personality is not possible without an understanding of the self.[12] Although self-awareness and the capacity to form complex self-representations are arguably the cardinal psychological characteristics of humans, most personality research ignores these processes, preferring the more concrete simplicity of personality traits (narrative approaches are a notable exception). However, many aspects of human behavior would be inexplicable without considering self-processes such as self-esteem, self-regulation, self-enhancement, self-deception, self-consciousness, and narrative identity. Over the past few decades, research has documented many ways in which self-processes influence how people think, feel, and act in particular situations, the goals they pursue in life, and the ways they cope with and adapt to new environments (Chen & Critcher, 2025; Robins, 2021).

There are numerous ways in which self-processes are directly relevant to personality. First, the self plays a critical role in personality processes. Many prominent areas of personality research assume a central role for the self, including research on constructs such as narcissism (e.g., Donnellan et al., 2021), internal working models of attachment (e.g., Fraley & Shaver, 2021), narrative identity (McAdams, 2021), ethnic/cultural identity (Oishi, Kushlev, & Benet-Martinez, 2021), self-regulation (Carver & Scheier, 2021; Hoyle & Davisson, 2021), and goals and motivation (e.g., Atherton, Grijalva, et al., 2021; Dweck, 2021; Sommet et al., 2021). Indeed, the self is the basis for an entire class of personality-relevant emotions, the so-called "self-conscious emotions" of pride, shame, guilt, and embarrassment—self-evaluative processes are central to the elicitation and regulation of these emotions (Tracy & Robins, 2004; Tracy et al., 2007; Tracy & Weidman, 2021).

Second, self and identity processes are considered key mechanisms underlying consistency and change in personality (e.g., Hennecke et al., 2014; Roberts & Nickel, 2021). For example, the TESSERA theoretical framework (Quintus et al., 2021; Wrzus & Roberts, 2017) proposes that the primary psychological mechanisms driving personality change are motivational constructs such as intentions and goals, reflective processes such as self-reflection and self-narration, and the capacity to self-regulate toward one's desired personality. Similarly, identity changes associated with the transition to early adulthood (e.g., seeing oneself as a parent or worker) promote higher levels of responsibility, interpersonal connections, and prosocial values, contributing to the normative increases in Conscientiousness and Agreeableness and decreases in Neuroticism observed during this stage of life. In contrast, self-verification processes – the tendency to seek out information, experiences, and social contexts that confirm one's pre-existing self-views (Swann, 1983) – can maintain stability in one's personality by creating more stable environments.

Third, the self plays a role in organizing the personality system. Personality psychology is an unusually broad field because it covers a wide spectrum of phenomena and levels of analysis, from genetic markers of traits to sociocultural perspectives on identity development. From our perspective, it is the self that ties together these various personality processes and, as Allport (1960) aptly put it, "makes the system cohere in any one person" (p. 308). Thus, studying personality without studying the self is like studying driving behavior but only paying attention to the car and not the driver.

Fourth, although personality psychologists have long been wary of research on the self, viewing it as purely phenomenological (or worse, epiphenomenal), a growing body of evidence suggests that many self-relevant constructs predict important real-world outcomes. Individuals with high self-esteem tend to have more satisfying social and romantic relationships, more success in school and work, better health, and lower levels of depression and criminal behavior (Orth & Robins, 2022a; Zell & Johansson, 2024). Similarly, the benefits of self-control are well-established and span multiple domains of functioning, including school, work, wealth, psychopathology, and health (Atherton et al., 2019; Cheng et al., 2024; Damian et al., 2020; Duckworth et al., 2019; Lawson et al., 2022; Moffitt et al., 2011; Serrano et al., 2022; Strauman, 2017).

Fifth, the science of the self is, in many ways, the science of personality psychology's most widely used methodological tool, self-reports. Consequently, a better understanding of the self-perception process, and the factors that influence accuracy and bias, will help us improve the validity of self-report personality tests by providing insight into *which traits* are most likely to be validly reported and *which individuals* are most likely to report accurately on their behavioral, cognitive, and affective tendencies.

Social-Contextual Processes

The person-situation debate caricatured personality and social psychologists as studying *either* persons or situations, yet many personality researchers study how personality is shaped by and manifested in different situations and life contexts (just as many social psychologists study individual-difference variables that capture important attitudes, beliefs, motives, construal tendencies, etc.). Research on situational influences often uses intensive experience sampling methods in which participants are assessed several times a day for a week or longer. Although this approach lacks the experimental control of social psychological research on situational effects, it reflects personality researchers' general emphasis on studying real-world behaviors. Personality research on situational influences has benefited from two noteworthy advances: (1) the availability of situational taxonomies such as the DIAMONDS model (Rauthmann et al., 2014; 2020) that provide a way to quantify how situations differ from each other and (2) the now voluminous body of research examining within-person personality processes over time. Research integrating these two approaches has shown that many personality states (what people think, feel, and do in the moment) are driven by complex person × situation interactions (Beck & Jackson, 2022c; Kuper et al., 2022; Kuper et al., 2024), consistent with Mischel's CAPS model and other social-cognitive theories of personality, and that findings observed at the between-person level do not always generalize to the within-person level (Beck & Jackson, 2020; 2021). It is important to note that research showing people express their traits differently across situations should not be taken to mean that the underlying trait itself is changing (or that stable personality traits do not exist), contrary to misinterpretations of this research in the media (e.g., "Personality can change from one hour to the next", Russo, 2023).

With regard to broader life contexts, there is increasing evidence that people are not passively shaped by the environment but rather actively seek out, modify, and even create environments consistent with their personalities. These processes, referred to as person-environment transactions, play out in several ways. First, personality traits "draw out" or elicit particular responses from the social environment. For example, friendly individuals may evoke more supportive responses from their peers, which reinforces their disposition to be friendly. Second, personality traits shape how people construe social situations. The same objective environment, such as a party, may mean something entirely different to an extravert (an opportunity to make friends) than an introvert (an anxiety-inducing situation). Third, individuals play an active role in selecting their social environments. Outgoing and sociable individuals may choose careers that fit their personality tendencies and shun solitary occupations with limited potential for social interaction. Together, these three processes promote a match between personality and social contexts. Consequently, many life experiences accentuate and reinforce the personality characteristics that were partially responsible for the experiences in the first place (Caspi & Moffitt, 1991). In other words, genetically based personality tendencies can snowball and shape the kind of life experiences one has, which in turn further solidifies those tendencies (Kandler et al., 2012).

These person-environment processes are central to research examining how life experiences and events influence personality development. Personality psychologists devote a great deal of effort to disentangling "*selection effects*" (i.e., how pre-existing personality traits influence which life experiences people have) and "*socialization effects*" (i.e., how life experiences shape personality). For example, Jackson and colleagues (2012) examined the effects of military service on personality change. They found several selection effects – individuals lower in agreeableness, neuroticism, and openness during high school were more likely to enter the military after graduation – as well as one socialization effect – individuals became even lower in agreeableness after serving in the military

(the socialization effect on agreeableness persisted four years later, even for participants who left the military and entered college or the labor market). People not only select into specific situations and contexts, they also select into broader social roles (getting married, becoming a parent, pursuing a particular career, etc.), which, in turn, have socialization effects on personality by shaping the situational norms, constraints, and expectations that govern their behavior and successful adaptation to the new role. Thus, personality and social-contextual factors have ongoing transactional associations over time.

The research discussed so far focuses on relatively proximal factors (a person's family, their job, the situation they are currently in), but a rapidly growing area of research has explored the possibility that more distal factors, such as the geographic region where a person lives, might influence personality (Rentfrow & Gosling, 2021). Research on "geo-psychology" has documented numerous ways in which certain personality traits tend to concentrate in specific regions of the world, areas within a country, or sections of a city (Bleidorn et al., 2016; Ebert et al., 2022; Elleman et al., 2018; Schmitt et al., 2007). For example, within the United States, individuals high in Openness tend to live in the New England and West Coast states (vs. the Midwest and Southern states) and in large metropolitan (vs. rural) areas. The distal effects of geographical location on personality are hypothesized to be driven by historical, economic, political, social, and, most notably, cultural factors that vary across geographical areas (Rentfrow et al., 2008; Rentfrow & Gosling, 2021). An alternative interpretation is that they are driven by reference group effects that vary across regions (Lenhausen et al., 2023). In the next section, we turn to the role of culture in shaping personality differences.

Cultural Processes

As noted earlier, individuals develop their personalities through dynamic, continuous, and reciprocal transactions with their social environments. A fundamental organizing force behind these environmental influences, affordances, and constraints is culture. We define culture as a system of symbols (what is represented), beliefs (what is considered true), values (what is considered important), norms (what is considered appropriate), and practices (what is performed) shared among interconnected individuals (Lu et al., 2023).[13] Culture accounts for a significant portion of the objective and symbolic macro- and micro-conditions that influence whether and how certain aspects of personality develop and are expressed (Bleidorn et al., 2013; Lu et al., 2023), including, for example, the value given to ego-focused traits and emotions such as self-esteem, pride, and excitement (Diener & Diener, 2009; Scollon et al., 2004; Tsai, 2007) and whether self-disclosure and emotional expressivity are normative (Rychlowska et al., 2015; Schug et al., 2010). Culture shapes personality because individuals are *always* embedded in cultural environments (for a detailed discussion of cultural differences in personality trait levels, structure, and development, see Section 4.1 in Lu et al., 2023).

Gordon Allport, despite his emphasis on internal personality traits, regarded culture as fundamental to an understanding of personhood: "Culture is in part a set of inventions that have arisen… to make life efficient and intelligible to mortals who struggle with the same basic problems of life: birth, growth, death, the pursuit of health, welfare, and meaning" (Allport, 1961, p. 168). But we are not passive recipients of the cultural forces operating in our social environments. Individuals selectively internalize culture's different elements, building versions of the American, Spanish, or Japanese "ways of life" in accordance with their personalities and needs. This variation results in a great deal of within-culture heterogeneity (for an excellent discussion of how within-cultural

heterogeneity and between-culture differences can be integrated conceptually and methodologically in the study of personality, see Oishi, 2004). Further, individuals might diverge from the dominant cultural norms and expectations (e.g., ethnic, sexual, and political minorities) and construct alternative self-definitions and "personalities" that can become new "cultures" (Dollbaum & Robertson, 2023; McLean et al., 2018; Westberg, 2022). In this sense, culture is not simply "out there," influencing *how personality develops*. It also influences *what personality is.*

Culture shapes individuals' personalities, but this process is bidirectional: individuals' personalities collectively shape culture (Lu et al., 2023). Individuals with different personalities invoke varying cultural elements (symbols, beliefs, values, norms, and practices) as they engage with their environment. At the aggregate level, the common patterns emerging from these cultural elements can reproduce or change culture. For example, regions where many individuals low in Openness and high in Neuroticism live have a higher percentage of votes cast for conservative (Republican) candidates in US elections and for conservative policies (Brexit) in the United Kingdom (Obschonka et al., 2018; Rentfrow, 2010). Thus, culture is one root of personality, while the aggregate influence of personality is one root of culture, rendering personality and culture interdependent.

Researchers interested in personality should consider other forms of culture. An individual's personality tendencies are shaped by the meanings, norms, and values attached to their gender, age, sexual orientation, religion, social class, and profession (Kashima & Gelfand, 2025; Lippa, 2007; Saroglou, 2010; Stephens et al., 2007; Thordisdottir et al., 2007). These forms of culture might be associated with unique socio-historical factors and ecological demands or share cultural values similar to those found in national and regional cultures (e.g., honor, tightness vs. looseness, individualism vs. collectivism). Consider, for example, the military and its emphasis on strict norms (culture of tightness); the premium men place on agency and autonomy (individualism); or Muslims' concerns with virtue and social reputation (honor).

It is essential for personality researchers to recognize the intersectionality of these different forms of culture in their research. Individuals respond to societal standards about personality expression, propriety, and success in ways that reflect their membership in multiple groups (e.g., Costa et al., 2001). Even when situations or tasks increase the salience of specific cultural identities (e.g., being a professor attending a scientific conference), the cultural meanings associated with other identities (e.g., being a woman, being from a culture where modesty is valued) might constrain or boost the expression of the dominant "cultural" demand (e.g., giving a talk with confidence). Personality research on identity intersectionality is still lacking, except for a study (Galinsky et al., 2013) showing that perceptions of masculine and feminine personality traits in the U.S. are guided by particular gender × race combinations, and that these gendered racial stereotypes have real-world consequences (i.e., they predict interracial marriage, leadership selection, and athletic participation).

In today's global society, individuals are exposed to, and influenced by, multiple cultures through immigration, travel, media, and other forms of transnational and intercultural contact. Individuals can thus hold multiple cultural identities reflecting their belonging to different forms of culture (Hong et al., 2000; Morris et al., 2015). Individuals' relationships with cultures are thus partial and plural, rather than categorical and singular (Morris et al, 2015). Research on multicultural identities has identified two main processes. First, individuals often switch between their different cultural selves in response to relevant situational cues, a process known as cultural frame-switching (Hong et al., 2000; Ramirez-Esparza et al., 2006). Second, some individuals can synergistically and harmoniously integrate their different cultural selves into a coherent self-concept, whereas others

cannot (Benet-Martinez & Haritatos, 2005). These variations, conceptualized as Bicultural Identity Integration (BII), are driven by differences in personality traits, life experiences, and contextual pressures (Benet-Martinez et al., 2021; Lilgendahl et al., 2018). There is accumulating evidence linking BII and cultural frame-switching to important outcomes, such as creativity, positive intergroup attitudes, psychological adjustment, and work and family engagement (Benet-Martinez et al., 2021). Thus, multicultural processes are psychologically consequential and indispensable for adaptive functioning in today's diverse world (Crisp & Meleady, 2012).

Research on multicultural identity highlights the importance of acculturation processes and the unique experience of growing up as a minoritized individual. Members of minoritized groups, especially immigrant communities, are uniquely impacted by experiences that are not shared by the majority culture, such as acculturative stress and social stratification mechanisms—racism, segregation, and prejudice—that permeate all levels of their environment and influence development (Causadias & Umaña-Taylor, 2018; García Coll et al., 1996). Most research on personality—how it develops and how it predicts important life outcomes—assumes that the core processes are universal. Yet, this assumption has not truly been tested because few studies focus on samples of people from minoritized ethnic groups (Bleidorn et al., 2022). The experience of different cultural systems—family, peer groups, school, community, etc.—is quite different from the vantage point of marginalized individuals (Vélez-Agosto et al., 2017). For example, Mexican-origin individuals living in the United States transition into adult social roles at an earlier age, and their personality may be shaped by culture-specific factors such as immigration status, ethnic identity, experiences of discrimination, acculturation gaps between family members, culturally prescribed parenting practices, and the clash between American values (e.g., individualism and independence) and Mexican cultural values (*familismo*, *respeto*), which can serve to increase risk or confer resilience. We have begun to explore, using data from the California Families Project, the extent to which Mexican-origin youth and adults show culture-specific patterns of development and how various cultural factors influence within-cultural variability in developmental trajectories (Atherton et al., 2020; 2022; Ringwald et al., 2024), but considerably more work is needed to understand how ethnicity and culture (and their intersection with other identities) shape personality (Arshad & Chung, 2022; Lu et al., 2023; Syed, 2024). In this context, personality psychologists can draw on some thoughtful work integrating culture and intersectionality in social psychological research (Ledgerwood et al., 2022; Roberts et al., 2020).

A culturally informed personality researcher, by being familiar with different "cultural logics" and "ideals" (Leung & Cohen, 2011), will be better equipped to correctly identify patterns of consistency and coherence in individual differences, and understand their meaning and consequentiality (e.g., the fit brought by being high in conscientiousness in a tight vs. loose culture; or what it means to be happy in a culture that emphasizes luck and fortune versus self-enhancement). In this sense, research on personality and culture has the potential to fulfill Allport's dream of a discipline that captures both the complexity of each individual's unique tendencies and the life-long transactions they have with their shared sociocultural worlds.

What Are The Real-World Consequences Of Personality For Important Life Outcomes?

There has been a long-standing tradition in social psychology to highlight the power of the situation on behavior (Ross & Nisbett, 1991; Zimbardo, 2007). Neither we nor any other personality

researchers question the power of the situation, but we do want to highlight the powerful impact of personality on behavior. Collectively, personality traits predict many of the outcomes that truly matter in life—health and mortality, academic success, job performance, the capacity to have a successful and lasting romantic relationship, and a wide range of personal and societal problems, including drug use and criminality (e.g., Beck & Jackson, 2022d; Borghans et al., 2016; Koepp et al., 2023; Ozer & Benet-Martínez, 2006; Roberts et al., 2007; Soto, 2019; 2021). Personality's predictive power is similar to the strength of situation effects (empirical research in social psychology and personality psychology yields about the same average effect sizes; Fraley & Marks, 2007; Gignac & Szodorai, 2016; Richard et al., 2003) and compares favorably to socioeconomic status and measures of cognitive ability such as IQ (Borghans et al., 2016; Roberts et al., 2007), as well as to many biomedical measures that predict diseases, such as ultrasound exams, screening mammograms, and electrocardiogram stress tests (Meyer et al., 2001). Below we summarize the main findings for several categories of life outcomes, including health and longevity; psychopathology; antisocial behavior, prosocial behavior, and civic responsibility; school and work; close relationships; cognitive function; and happiness and life satisfaction.

Health And Longevity

Health and longevity are obviously outcomes of great importance to individuals and society. Decades ago, Friedman and Rosenman (1959) published their landmark study showing an association between the "Type A" personality and cardiovascular disease. In the subsequent 65 years, the study of personality and health has grown into a large and thriving area of research. Multiple large-scale studies and meta-analyses show that conscientious people live longer than people who are irresponsible and unreliable (Jokela et al., 2020; Graham et al., 2017; Roberts et al., 2007; Strickhouser et al., 2017). The association between Conscientiousness and longevity can be explained by the fact that conscientious individuals engage in behaviors that promote health (e.g., exercise, following doctors' recommendations, etc.), refrain from behaviors that lead to health problems (e.g., eating junk food, drug and alcohol abuse, risky sexual behavior, unsafe driving, etc.), and experience positive outcomes in other domains (e.g., educational and occupational success) that subsequently reduce risk of mortality (Bogg & Roberts, 2004; Hill & Jackson, 2016). In addition, individuals who are emotionally stable (i.e., low in Neuroticism), high in positive emotionality, and optimistic tend to live longer (Friedman & Hampson, 2021; Graham et al., 2017; Jokela et al., 2020).

Psychopathology

Personality traits are robustly associated with most forms of psychopathology. Internalizing disorders like anxiety and depression are strongly related to Neuroticism, as well as low Extraversion and Conscientiousness (Tackett & Mullins-Sweatt, 2021). Externalizing disorders like aggression and substance abuse are associated with high Neuroticism, low Agreeableness, and low Conscientiousness. Thought disorders are associated with high Neuroticism, low Extraversion, and, possibly, high Openness. Interestingly, the Big Five correlates of different psychiatric disorders generally replicate at the genetic level (Grotzinger et al., 2022), suggesting, for example, that the genetic variance in internalizing disorders is correlated with the genetic variance in Neuroticism.

Maladaptive levels of normal-range personality traits are also characteristic of various personality disorders (Widiger & Oltmanns, 2021). Numerous developmental models have been proposed to explain the personality-psychopathology links. For example, the *vulnerability model* posits that existing personality traits predispose individuals to subsequently develop mental health problems,

whereas the *scar model* hypothesizes that experiencing mental health problems changes, or scars, underlying personality traits. Research supports the validity of both models (Tackett, 2006; Tackett & Mullins-Sweatt, 2021).

Beyond studies documenting links between personality and psychopathology, researchers working at the intersection of these areas have revolutionized the field of psychopathology in two ways. First, personality disorders, such as Borderline Personality Disorder and Narcissistic Personality Disorder, are now widely conceptualized and studied as continuous (rather than categorical) disorders that can be modeled as particular configurations of the maladaptive poles of the Big Five domains (e.g., Hopwood et al., 2018; Krueger et al., 2011; Widiger & Oltmanns, 2021). Second, personality researchers played a central role in moving clinical psychology and psychiatry toward a dimensional (i.e., continuous) model of *all* psychiatric disorders, not just personality disorders, with the development of the Hierarchical Taxonomy of Psychopathology (HiTOP) (DeYoung et al., 2022; Kotov et al., 2018; Widiger et al., 2019).

Antisocial Behavior, Prosocial Behavior, And Civic Responsibility

Meta-analytic findings suggest that agreeable and conscientious individuals are less likely to engage in antisocial behavior (Miller & Lynam, 2001), whereas antagonistic and impulsive individuals are more likely to engage in delinquency and be convicted of crimes. Meta-analytic findings also indicate that agreeable individuals, and those high on the conceptually related domain of honesty-humility, demonstrate higher levels of prosocial behavior in experimental tasks such as the Dictator Game, Trust Game, Prisoner's Dilemma, and Commons Dilemma; in contrast, individuals scoring high on the so-called "dark triad" traits (narcissism, psychopathy, Machiavellianism) tend to exhibit low levels of prosocial behavior in these tasks (Thielmann et al., 2020).

Personality is also associated with adaptive contributions to society and moral character, including voting behavior, volunteerism, gratitude, and forgiveness (e.g., Haider & von Stumm, 2022; Ozer & Benet-Martinez, 2006; Soto, 2019). In a large, representative sample of emerging adults in the U.K., personality traits including the Big Five, grit, curiosity, and ambition were strong predictors of a wide range of social-emotional outcomes (e.g., purpose in life, volunteering); in most cases, personality was a better predictor of these outcomes than intelligence or socioeconomic status (Haider & von Stumm, 2022). Furthermore, individuals high in Openness and Extraversion and low in Neuroticism are more politically involved (Bromme et al., 2022). Personality traits predict voting behavior (Barbaranelli et al., 2007) and attitudes toward foreign policy (Chagas-Bastos, 2024) as well or better than the traditional demographic variables that political scientists and the media focus on. [14] Finally, in the workplace, high Agreeableness and Conscientiousness are positively associated with a wide range of prosocial work attitudes, values, and behaviors, and negatively associated with counterproductive work attitudes, values, and behaviors (Sackett & Walmsley, 2014; Wilmot & Ones, 2022).

Close Relationships

Meta-analytic findings suggest that low Neuroticism is the strongest and most consistent personality predictor of relationship satisfaction (Heller et al., 2004; Malouff et al., 2010); neurotic people report less satisfaction in their romantic relationships and more conflict, abuse, and dissolution (Soto, 2019). Other Big Five traits are also robustly associated with relationship functioning; individuals higher in Agreeableness, Conscientiousness, and Extraversion report more

relationship satisfaction than their disagreeable, irresponsible, and introverted counterparts (Soto, 2019).

These findings extend beyond self-reports of personality; studies based on the Actor-Partner Independence Model using self-, partner-, and meta-perceptions of personality show that Neuroticism is negatively linked to relationship satisfaction and Agreeableness and Conscientiousness are positively related to relationship satisfaction across all three personality perceptions (Schaffhuser et al., 2014). These associations likely work through intermediary processes of interpersonal behaviors and emotion regulation during interactions with romantic partners, which have been shown to mediate the relation between personality and relationship satisfaction (Donnellan et al., 2007; Vater & Schröder-Abé, 2015). Personality is also associated with divorce; individuals who are neurotic, disagreeable, and low in Conscientiousness are more likely to get divorced (Roberts et al., 2007). These findings are linked through a temporal sequence; specifically, personality traits such as Neuroticism influence the overall quality of one's relationship, which in turn influences the likelihood of relationship dissolution (Solomon and Jackson, 2014). Finally, in addition to romantic relationships, personality is also linked to satisfaction in peer relationships, with Extraversion, Agreeableness, and (low) Neuroticism associated with having satisfying friendships (Harris & Vazire, 2016; Wilson et al., 2015).

School And Work

Meta-analytic findings suggest that Conscientiousness is the best personality predictor of school performance (Mammadov, 2022; Noftle & Robins, 2007; Spielmann et al., 2022) and job performance (Barrick et al., 2001; Sackett & Walmsley, 2014). Importantly, Conscientiousness predicts performance in these domains above and beyond the effects of traditional measures of cognitive ability (e.g., IQ tests and standardized achievement tests), despite the well-documented associations between Conscientiousness and cognitive ability (Stanek & Ones, 2023). In fact, Nobel Prize-winning economist James Heckman and his colleagues have argued in a series of papers that personality (especially traits related to the Conscientiousness domain) predicts school grades as well as achievement tests, and personality predicts educational attainment and salary as well as IQ (e.g., Borghans et al., 2016; Heckman et al., 2021).

Cognitive Function And Impairment

Numerous studies have shown that the Big Five domains are associated with cognitive function across adulthood. Individuals who score higher in Openness and Conscientiousness tend to have better cognitive function, whereas individuals who score higher in Neuroticism tend to have worse cognitive function (Graham et al., 2021; Stanek & Ones, 2023; Sutin et al., 2019). Higher Openness and Conscientiousness, and lower Neuroticism, are also associated with lower risk of cognitive impairment and less cognitive decline across older adulthood (Aschwanden et al., 2021; Terracciano & Sutin, 2019; Yoneda et al., 2023), and lower Neuroticism is associated with reduced risk of neurodegeneration (a predictor of Alzheimer's disease) prior to the onset of cognitive impairment (Terracciano et al. 2023). Individuals high in Openness may seek out cognitively complex tasks (e.g., doing crossword puzzles, using new technology) and engage in abstract, creative thinking that contributes to better cognitive function (Curtis et al., 2015). Similarly, conscientious individuals tend to be hardworking, organized, diligent, and deliberate in their thinking and more motivated to achieve in structured settings, contributing to better cognitive function. Conversely, highly neurotic individuals tend to be anxious, angry, and distressed, so they may get more frustrated

when completing challenging cognitive tasks and ruminate about poor task performance, leading to worse cognitive function. The other two Big Five domains, Extraversion and Agreeableness, do not show replicable associations with cognitive function, with some studies finding significant associations (e.g., Sutin et al., 2019) and others finding no associations (e.g., Graham et al., 2021).

Happiness And Life Satisfaction

Personality influences a person's overall happiness and life satisfaction (Heller et al., 2004). Not surprisingly, individuals who are less neurotic report having the most satisfying lives. In addition, extraverted, agreeable, and conscientious individuals are generally happier than those low on these traits. Personality (specifically high Extraversion and optimism and low Neuroticism) is a stronger predictor of subjective well-being than external circumstances (Lucas & Diener, 2021). Notably, a recent study based on three large samples and multi-method (self and informant) assessments of personality found moderately strong associations between personality (high Extraversion and Conscientiousness, low Neuroticism) and life satisfaction (*rs* = .30 to .50), even after controlling for shared method variance between the personality and life satisfaction measures (Mõttus et al., 2024).

Summary

As this review shows, personality has robust associations with a wide range of life outcomes. Many of the findings reviewed above are based on meta-analyses or analyses of large nationally representative data sets. Not surprisingly, the findings have proven to be highly replicable. A large-scale project successfully replicated 87% of the pre-registered associations between personality traits and individual (e.g., physical and mental health, subjective well-being), interpersonal (e.g., romantic relationship satisfaction, peer status), and social-institutional outcomes (e.g., occupational satisfaction, criminal behavior) (Soto, 2019). Follow-up analyses showed that most personality-outcome associations generalized across age, gender, and ethnicity, suggesting that these associations are robust across demographic groups (Soto, 2021).[15] Moreover, although we have focused our review on the Big Five domains, other constructs related to personality, such as self-esteem, also have replicable associations with many of the same life outcomes (Orth & Robins, 2022a; Zell & Johannson, 2024).

A recent analysis showed that personality research is the most replicable of the six main subareas of psychology (Youyou et al., 2023). Baumeister (2016) argued that personality research is replicable because it is "boring," but we (and Youyou et al., 2023) believe it has more to do with methodological rigor – including paying close attention to measurement issues, conducting studies with large sample sizes, an emphasis on meta-analytic findings and findings based on analyses of multiple large-scale datasets pooled together, a lack of fixation on novel findings, an emphasis on effect sizes rather than significance levels, and a research culture that encourages, or at least does not discourage, publishing null findings. Another consideration is that many of the leaders of the "credibility revolution" (the response to the replication crisis in psychology) were personality psychologists, leading many in the field to become early adopters of research practices that promote replicability such as pre-registering studies (Atherton , Chung, et al., 2021). Regardless, we hope this chapter will convince readers that the field is not, in fact, boring.

Whether boring or not, there are several reasons why researchers (and the public) should care about evidence demonstrating that personality predicts life outcomes. First, it helps identify

individuals most at risk for particular outcomes. For example, if we know that individuals who are low in conscientiousness are at greater risk for health problems, less likely to get medical check-ups, and less likely to follow healthcare recommendations, then we know that targeted interventions (e.g., more frequent reminders about medical check-ups and taking medications) are likely to produce stronger benefits in this subpopulation. Second, evidence that individuals with poor self-control (as indicated by traits such as conscientiousness) experience a wide range of adverse outcomes (health problems, academic failure, poor job performance, etc.) highlights the need for personality-targeted interventions that aim to improve their self-regulatory skills. Moreover, personality assessments can be used to tailor interventions for people with different personality dispositions, just as precision medicine identifies treatments that work well for particular individuals. For example, a health intervention that requires a considerable amount of self-regulatory skills might work well for people high in Conscientiousness, but an alternative intervention might be needed for those low in Conscientiousness (Matz et al., 2023). Third, cumulative research on the real-world consequences of different traits improves our theoretical understanding of these traits. For example, the life outcomes associated with Agreeableness and Conscientiousness support the interpretation of these domains as driven by underlying caregiving and self-regulatory biobehavioral systems, whereas the dearth of real-world outcomes associated with Openness raises questions about whether it truly reflects an underlying exploratory system, or perhaps whether we are simply measuring the wrong outcomes to confirm this theorized connection (Schwaba, 2019; Schwaba et al., 2019).

It is important to emphasize that the effects of personality on life outcomes are probabilistic not deterministic. In other words, an individual's personality may increase the likelihood that they will experience particular life outcomes, but they are by no means destined to experience those outcomes. Relatedly, the effect sizes tend to be small in an absolute sense; that is, personality generally explains a small percentage of variance in the outcome. However, small effect sizes may accumulate to larger effects over the course of a person's life and may be particularly consequential when aggregated to the population level (Funder & Ozer, 2019; Götz et al., 2022). For example, Rosenthal (1990) noted that taking aspirin (vs. placebo) prevented approximately 85 heart attacks in a sample of 11,037 physicians, despite a very modest .03 correlation between taking aspirin and decreased risk for heart attacks. Given the robust, well-established findings, personality psychologists have argued for the policy relevance of personality traits, suggesting that traits may be actionable targets for interventions to promote individual well-being and improve society at large (Bleidorn et al., 2019).

In the concluding sections of this chapter, we (a) apply what we have learned from our review of the literature to the case of Chuck Graner; (b) discuss some persistent myths about the field of personality psychology (as well as some inconvenient truths about the shortcomings of personality research); (c) describe what it means to take a personality approach to the study of psychological phenomena; and (d) present recommendations that, we hope, will promote further integration and collaboration between personality and social psychologists, helping both groups attain their overlapping research goals.

APPLYING WHAT WE HAVE LEARNED: THE CASE OF CHUCK GRANER

How can personality research be used to gain a deeper understanding of a particular individual's actions? McAdams's (2020) masterful book on President Trump provides a blueprint for how all aspects of personality psychology are needed to provide a comprehensive account of one of the most unique personalities of the last several decades. Throughout his book, McAdams weaves a complex account of how Trump's traits, motives, and narratives are manifested in a wide range of different contexts; traces the developmental roots of his personality tendencies; attempts to infer the cognitive and affective processes (i.e., thoughts and feelings) that mediate, moderate, and trigger different behavioral expressions of Trump's stable personality tendencies; and explores the nuanced ways in which the environment, including specific situational triggers and more general life contexts, help explain when and why the trait, motive, and narrative aspects of his personality are expressed in concrete behaviors.

In this section, we will present a more concise analysis of another controversial individual, Chuck Graner, the leader of the guards who brutalized prisoners in Abu Ghraib. Let's return to the horrific events discussed at the beginning of this chapter. What insights can be gleaned from contemporary personality research that help explain the violent abuse committed by Graner in a military prison on the outskirts of Baghdad? In each of the points below, we draw on what we have learned from earlier sections of the chapter about personality structure, measurement, development, processes, and real-world implications.

First, and perhaps most important, Graner's behavior in the Abu Ghraib prison is likely part of a long-term tendency to engage in violent and antisocial acts. We know from our review of research on the structure of personality that we can characterize Graner as having a constellation of personality traits, motives, and narrative identities that predispose him to violence. There is ample evidence from Graner's life that he is particularly low in Agreeableness (i.e., not kind, caring, or compassionate) and Conscientiousness (i.e., not reliable or responsible), and high on the angry hostility (BFI-2) facet of Neuroticism, all three of which collectively define the meta-trait of Stability. Indeed, Graner's life history reads like a litany of violent and repulsive acts, including stalking and beating his ex-wife, putting mace in a fellow prison guard's coffee, and planting a razor blade in the food of a prisoner at a civilian prison (von Zielbauer & Dao, 2005; Wikipedia, 2024). With regard to motivation, he seems particularly motivated by power and admiration, and exhibits narcissistic tendencies such as entitlement and exploitation of others. Reflecting both his toxic traits and his narcissistic motives, Graner manipulated another prison guard, Lynndie England, his girlfriend at the time, into engaging in some of the most sadistic forms of abuse at Abu Ghraib, and he later refused to acknowledge that he is the father of her child (despite a positive paternity test).

It is difficult to infer Graner's narrative identity from the available biographical information, but his long history with the military (he joined the Marines soon after graduating from high school), and the fact that he had the U.S. Marine Corp emblem and the letters "USMC" tattooed on his arm, suggests that his identity is integrally tied to his military service. He clearly sees being a soldier as a core part of who he is. In this respect, he may share with President Trump an identity as a "warrior" (McAdams, 2016), which could have provided coherence and justification for his combative and cruel behavior toward prisoners, who through the lens of his warrior identity he might have seen as his personal foes.

Second, we know from research on measuring personality that Graner's traits can be reliably and accurately measured with well-validated personality tests or informant reports using standardized personality scales. Graner almost certainly completed personality tests as part of the personnel selection process when he joined the military and when he applied to work in a civilian prison. If

we had access to his scores, we could test our hypotheses about which specific traits he is particularly high or low on. Informant reports from his ex-wife and fellow prison guards would probably support our interpretation of Graner as being low in Agreeableness and Conscientiousness, and high in angry hostility, as would the military investigator who delved deeply into Graner's behavior and reputation and described him as "the biggest S.O.B. on the earth" (Scelfo, 2004). Behavioral measures (e.g., EAR recordings from Graner going about his daily life at Abu Ghraib) would likely capture frequent antagonistic and hostile behaviors.

Third, we know from the section on personality development that Graner's violent personality likely developed through the mutual and interactive influence of his genotype and his lived experiences. Graner likely selected himself into environments in which his violent personality was nurtured and easily expressed (i.e., selection effects), including, for example, joining the Marines and working at a civilian prison. His violent personality tendencies may have shaped his construal of the prison environment as a context in which violence was encouraged and rewarded; his violent personality likely elicited hostile reactions from prisoners and guards that further fueled his violent behavior. However, we cannot blame Graner's parents for his personality because shared environmental influences such as parenting have weak effects on personality development; in fact, if Graner had an identical twin raised in a different family, his twin would likely also be prone to violence, despite being raised by different parents.

Fourth, we know from the section on personality development that Graner was probably even more violent and antisocial earlier in his life, long before he worked at the Abu Ghraib prison when he was about 36 years old. If he followed the normative pattern exemplified by the maturity principle of personality development, he likely experienced positive changes in his personality (i.e., increases in Agreeableness and Conscientiousness, and decreases in Neuroticism) as he transitioned from adolescence and into adulthood, which would have dampened his violent tendencies by the time he engaged in prison abuse at Abu Ghraib. Despite these changes in the absolute level of his personality traits, his standing on these traits relative to others probably remained fairly stable—that is, he may have become more agreeable and conscientious as he got older, but he almost certainly remained far below average on these traits; indeed, his long-term history of violent and malicious behavior testifies to the stability of his personality over time and across contexts.

Fifth, it is possible Graner could have learned to temper his violent tendencies through systematic personality-targeted interventions, in either a clinical or non-clinical setting. However, we are dubious that personality interventions would work for Graner because they are only effective for individuals who acknowledge their personality flaws, commit to changing their personality, and proactively and persistently engage in volitional actions to facilitate change, which Graner seems unlikely to have done.

Sixth, we know from the section on personality processes that although Graner has a violent personality, his violent behavior would not be expressed in all situations, only in those that trigger his violent nature, such as the Abu Ghraib prison, and only in certain contexts and at certain times within the prison context. That is, Graner's behavior is best thought of as a function of the person (his violent personality), the situation (pressure from his superiors to get information from prisoners, a general dehumanization of the "enemy," Islamophobia ignited after the 9/11 terrorist attacks), and the interaction between these two factors (i.e., the particularly toxic mix of a violent person placed in a violence-eliciting context). More specifically, based on what we know about the relevant social-cognitive processes, Graner might exhibit a hostile attribution bias that makes him more vigilant to cues related to violence, more likely to perceive ambiguous social cues as

threatening and confrontative, more likely to feel insulted or attacked by others, and more likely to have mental representations of his beliefs, emotions, and action tendencies (BEATS) that provide an easily activated and automatized script for engaging in violence.

Seventh, broader sociocultural and contextual factors likely played an essential role in the development of Graner's violent personality. As noted earlier, his identity seems very much tied to his service as a Marine, which has its own subculture that arguably promotes a warrior mentality and normative tightness (i.e., strong norms and harsher punishment of deviance), and which research suggests leads to declines in Agreeableness (i.e., becoming less kind and compassionate; Jackson et al., 2012). Moreover, Graner's cultural identity as an American, and specifically an American soldier, and perhaps a belief in American exceptionalism, may have contributed to his conviction that he had a right, even a duty, to humiliate and torture prisoners for the greater good of defeating the enemy in the U.S. war in Iraq.

Eighth, we know from the section on the real-world implications of personality that Graner's personality profile indicates he is at increased risk for a wide range of negative outcomes. In fact, he has already exhibited or experienced many of these outcomes, including antisocial behavior (he engaged in prison abuse and denied being the father of his child), psychopathology (he appears to have at least some symptoms of antisocial personality disorder), relationship problems (he committed spousal abuse and his ex-wife received a restraining order against him), academic problems (he dropped out of college), and occupational problems (he was dishonorably discharged from the military and received multiple reprimands and suspensions and was eventually fired from his job in a civilian prison). We found no evidence suggesting that he is suffering from cognitive impairment or other health problems, but we know little about his current life circumstances because he refuses to talk to the media and, regardless, he is still relatively young to experience these problems.

We hope this brief analysis of Chuck Graner exemplifies how personality research can provide important insights into an individual case. Clearly, much of this analysis is speculative, given the dearth of information about Graner's life (especially before adulthood), but we can nonetheless discern a thread of continuity in the behaviors he exhibits over time and across contexts. What is missing from this analysis is a more nuanced and complete understanding of the situational triggers that explain when and why Graner exhibited certain behaviors in some situations but not in others. It is one thing to determine that people with a particular set of personality characteristics have a higher probability of engaging in a particular behavior, but it is vastly more complicated to understand and explain when and why they will actually exhibit that behavior.

In this sense, personality psychologists are like weather reporters who identify broad regularities and patterns (e.g., it's hot in the summer, cold in the winter, just as some people, like Graner, are generally hot-headed whereas others are coolly reserved). But, our models and explanatory frameworks do not allow us to predict, with much precision, whether a hot-headed person will get into a particularly belligerent argument with their relationship partner that day (just as weather reporters are not great at predicting deviations from average temperatures on any given day). It is easier to make predictions and identify situational triggers when talking about personality units in terms of needs and motives, because these can be matched more easily to specific situations (e.g., school and work fulfill a need for achievement, competition a need for power, parties a need for affiliation, and dates a need for intimacy), but for traits it is difficult without falling into tautological explanations. This gaping hole in the personality analysis highlights the need for personality and

social psychologists to work together, with both areas contributing their relative expertise to provide a more accurate and nuanced understanding of persons, situations, and behaviors.

MYTHS AND INCONVENIENT TRUTHS

As our overview of the field shows, personality psychology has moved toward social psychology over the past decade, with an increasing emphasis on situation-specific personality patterns, cultural influences on personality, personality change following significant life experiences, narrative identity (which is inherently contextual), and constructs related to self-processes (self-regulation, narcissism, self-esteem) that are of interest to both research communities. Nonetheless, although the person-situation debate is largely in the past, social and personality psychologists still mostly stay in their own lanes, pursuing their research agendas with little consideration of relevant research conducted by those in the sibling discipline. In our experience, many personality psychologists have limited knowledge of social psychological theory and research, and many social psychologists have limited knowledge of personality theory and research.

One impediment to integration and collaboration is outdated and inaccurate perceptions of personality research. Although by no means ubiquitous, some non-personality researchers still envision a "caricature" of a personality psychologist as somebody who toils away factor analyzing self-reported Big Five traits and correlating them with self-reports of other variables. Although this stereotype may accurately characterize some personality research conducted decades ago, this is hardly an accurate portrayal of contemporary research in the field. Indeed, one of the most striking findings from our survey of personality and social researchers is that both groups substantially overestimate their differences, viewing the "typical" social psychologist or "typical" personality psychologist as diverging dramatically in their *underlying assumptions* (e.g., beliefs about the importance of dispositional vs. situational factors and the degree of cross-situational consistency vs. situation specificity) and *methods* (e.g., use of experimental vs. correlational designs); these caricatures of each field were more than 1.5 standard deviations larger than the *actual* differences between personality and social psychologists in their underlying assumptions and methods (Tracy et al., 2009b). We have little doubt that such misperceptions persist to this day, but we would be happy to have someone conduct a study to prove us wrong.

Thus, one way to promote integration and bridge the divide between the two areas would be to expose the inaccuracy of stereotypes about each field. Although we believe personality psychologists need this re-education just as much as social psychologists, given the focus of this chapter we will devote this section to countering "myths" about the field of personality psychology that we believe are at least somewhat prevalent among social psychologists, as well as researchers from other areas of psychology. Some of these myths were accurate at one point in the field's history but continue to persist despite repeated efforts to counter them (making them akin to "zombie ideas"). These lingering myths have pernicious effects because they may lead researchers to question the value of personality research and create barriers to collaborative work by making it seem like the conceptual and methodological divide between the two areas is too difficult to bridge.

Table 3 presents a set of pervasive myths about personality psychology, our response and analysis of each myth, and an "inconvenient truth" related to the myth (i.e., a kernel of truth that personality researchers may prefer not to acknowledge). Some of these myths are conceptual (e.g., personality is fixed and cannot change), while others are methodological (e.g., personality researchers only collect self-report data). We believe the table speaks for itself, but we do want to make a few general points.

First, we generally do not provide citations to support our assertions because most of the points in the table reiterate material from previous sections of the chapter. Although this creates some redundancy, we think it will be helpful for readers to have all these key points summarized together.

***Table 3*: Myths and Inconvenient Truths About the Field of Personality Psychology**

Myth 1	The field of personality is guided by overly broad, vague, and largely debunked theoretical perspectives.
Response and Analysis	• These so-called grand theories of personality (Freud, Skinner, Jung, Maslow, etc.) have little impact on the vast majority of research conducted in the field, except in a very generic way (e.g., unconscious processes matter).
Inconvenient Truth	• Many undergraduate courses/textbooks in personality psychology continue to focus on these grand theories. • No new unified and consensual comprehensive theory has emerged to replace the grand theories. • Compared to social psychology (and other areas of psychology), the field has fewer mid-level theoretical models that guide research.
Myth 2	Personality researchers only study traits (and only care about the Big Five).
Response and Analysis	• The majority of personality studies focus on traits, but researchers also study goals/motivation, values, narrative identity, socioemotional skills, affective dispositions (e.g., gratitude, pride, hostility), self-related constructs (self-esteem, narcissism), vocational interests, and many other constructs. • Personality researchers use the Big Five as an organizing framework for research on a vast range of individual-difference constructs. This reduces jingle-jangle problems and facilitates aggregation of results across studies.
Inconvenient Truth	• A disproportionate amount of personality research continues to focus on traits, and most meta-analyses use the Big Five as an organizing framework.
Myth 3	Personality researchers only use self-report measures.
Response and Analysis	• Self-report personality tests are very commonly used, but researchers use a broad range of other measures to assess personality, including personality ratings by peers, teachers, and parents; behavioral measures in structured and unstructured settings; performance on cognitive-behavioral tasks; data mining of social media activity; narrative identity assessments; and various physiological/neural measures (see section on Personality Assessment and Table 1).
Inconvenient Truth	• Most personality research relies heavily on self-report personality tests. For example, meta-analyses of personality development or the effects of personality on life outcomes are predominantly (but not exclusively) based on self-report personality tests.
Myth 4	Self-report measures are not valid.
Response and Analysis	• Self-report personality tests are often the best option for reliably and validly assessing stable individual differences in constructs of interest to personality researchers. • Despite their flaws, self-report personality tests generally perform better than other measures of the same constructs, with higher reliability and better construct validity. • Every widely used personality test has gone through years of development and validation, and measures lacking in validity (e.g., the MBTI) are rarely, if ever, used in research contexts.
Inconvenient Truth	• Over-reliance on self-report measures poses the risk that our findings are based on how people see themselves, not how they actually are.
Myth 5	Personality researchers do not study, or care about, causal processes.
Response and Analysis	• Personality researchers certainly care about causation. In most studies, there are theoretical (or at least intuitive) reasons to believe the effects are causal (e.g., between personality and life outcomes). • Personality researchers use sophisticated research designs (e.g., discordant twin design, McGue et al., 2010) and statistical methods (e.g., propensity score matching, DAGs; Beck & Jackson, 2022d; Chatton & Rohrer, 2024; Rohrer, 2024; Schwaba & Bleidorn, 2019) to infer causal processes with non-experimental, observational data. • Personality researchers sometimes leverage experimental designs to address causal research questions or take advantage of natural experiments to make causal inferences (Grosz et al., 2024). Recent advances in personality-focused interventions (which can be randomly assigned to participants) should fuel more experimental research.
Inconvenient Truth	• A great deal of personality research is overly descriptive, with little or no explanatory framework. We need more theoretical models that specify testable hypotheses about causal processes to guide our research (Bleidorn, 2023).
Myth 6	Personality is fixed and does not change.
Response and Analysis	• Extensive longitudinal research has documented the many ways personality changes across the lifespan. • Personality change occurs naturally as people age, but also when people are motivated to improve their personality through their own actions or through clinical and non-clinical interventions. • This research counters a related myth, namely that it is not useful to document the real-world consequences of personality because there is no way to change personality.
Inconvenient Truth	• Personality researchers devote considerable effort toward describing general trends and patterns of personality development and change, but we lack a deep understanding of what accounts for these trends and patterns.
Myth 7	Personality researchers ignore or deny the impact of the situation on behavior.
Response and Analysis	• When personality psychologists argue that personality is an important cause of behavior, this does not mean they think situations do not matter (see Footnote 2). As Funder (2006) noted, main effects of situations do not imply an absence of person effects, or vice versa. • Nearly all personality researchers are interactionists, viewing behavior as a function of the person, the situation, and their interaction. As Roberts and Yoon (2022) noted, "No personality psychologist claimed that extraverted people would talk the same amount at a bar or at a funeral." • Numerous ESM/EMA studies have shown that the *expression* of personality changes in response to features of the situation. To better understand these situational forces, personality psychologists have devoted considerable effort toward developing taxonomies of situations (Rauthmann et al., 2020).
Inconvenient Truth	• Most relevant research examines persons in everyday life contexts, with no experimental control over the situations that people experience. Consequently, it is difficult to isolate causal effects of situations (or person-situation interactions) on behavior.
Myth 8	Personality researchers ignore or deny the impact of context (environmental factors) in shaping personality.
Response and Analysis	• Virtually all personality psychologists believe that environmental factors play a role in shaping personality; few conform to the caricature of a trait psychologist as someone who believes personality is entirely genetically determined and immutable (see Footnote 2). • A great deal of personality development research focuses on the impact of life events and reciprocal person-environment transactions, all theories of personality development (e.g., Social Investment Theory) consider social-contextual factors. • Many other areas of personality research explicitly consider contextual factors, such as behavioral genetic research on shared and non-shared environmental effects, cross-cultural personality research, geo-psychology, narrative research, etc.
Inconvenient Truth	• We know little about the processes that explain how and why specific contexts and experiences change personality. • There is a schism between researchers who study persons in situations (e.g., ESM studies) and those who study broad contextual factors. That is, research examining how personality is expressed in our daily lives, as we go from situation to situation, is largely disconnected from work examining how we change as we grow older, experience major life events, and transition into adult social roles. • Integrating these two streams seems essential to understanding how situations and broader contextual factors jointly shape personality.
Myth 9	Personality does not matter in the real world.

Response and Analysis	• Numerous meta-analyses have documented robust effects of personality on numerous important life outcomes.
Inconvenient Truth	• We know that personality matters, but we often do not know why. • In some areas of research (e.g., the association between Conscientiousness and health), we have identified mediating processes that explain the effects, but more often we have a well-replicated association that awaits an explanation.
Myth 10	Personality research is boring.
Response and Analysis	• We hope this chapter proves otherwise.
Inconvenient Truth	• A great deal of personality research remains devoted to documenting effects that match people's intuitions (e.g., conscientious individuals do better in school).

Note: See the main text for additional material and citations supporting the assertions in this table.

Second, to further support some of our assertions, we obtained more concrete data on the methods used by present-day personality psychologists. Specifically, the first author coded all articles published in Volume 123 (2022) of the *Personality Processes and Individual Differences* (PPID) subsection of *JPSP*. Thirteen (72%) of the 18 articles in Vol. 123 used multiple assessment methods (almost always self-report plus one or more non-self-report methods). Of the five articles that relied exclusively on self-reports, four focused on subjective/phenomenological constructs that are arguably best assessed by self-report (two examined life satisfaction, one examined life satisfaction and self-esteem, and another examined political attitudes). Thus, 93% (13 of 14) of the articles that focused on more objective personality constructs (e.g., Big Five domains) used multi-method assessment. It is also noteworthy that more than three-fourths (78%) of the articles included repeated assessments over time, either longitudinal data (in most cases) or experience sampling data.

Finally, some of our assertions may be contentious, not just among social psychologists but also among personality psychologists. We hope that the table spurs further discussion, debate, and, of course, more research related to these topics. More generally, we hope our compilation of myths and inconvenient truths will promote a shared understanding among social and personality psychologists and further quell the sibling rivalry between the two disciplines.

A PERSONALITY APPROACH TO STUDYING PSYCHOLOGICAL PHENOMENA

At this point, readers should be acquainted with the breadth of personality research and current knowledge in the field. We hope it is clear that taking a personality approach toward one's subject matter does not mean simply including a Big Five measure in your study; there is much more to the approach than that. Some readers who do not identify as personality psychologists may be interested in introducing personality theories, methods, and findings into their work, but unsure where to begin. In this section, we provide a point-by-point description of what we consider the "personality approach" to research, a road map for psychologists who want to adopt a more personality-oriented approach to their topic of study, whether they are studying prejudice, relationship functioning, self-regulation, morality, or any other psychological phenomenon that has an individual-differences component.

In Table 4, we enumerate the specific conceptual and methodological components of a personality approach to studying individual differences. In some sense, this is akin to articulating the "culture" of personality research, as it relates to the consensually shared norms, values, and practices of this research community. Although many components described in the table are not unique to personality psychology or implemented by every personality psychologist, the combined set of components collectively defines the research culture of the field.

***Table 4*: A Personality Approach to Studying Individual Differences**

Conceptual aspects of the approach
1. ***Assume that people differ from each other in fundamentally important ways*** and that these differences have a causal impact on people's thoughts, feelings and behaviors.
2. ***Conceptualize individual-difference characteristics in terms of the "personality triad" (thoughts, feelings, and behaviors)***, rather than thinking about cognitive, affective, *or* behavioral constructs. Similarly, when considering the impact of situational factors, examine how the situation influences the thoughts, feelings, *and* behaviors associated with the individual-difference construct.
3. ***Conceptualize individual-difference characteristics in terms of the degree to which they reflect how each person is like all other people (i.e., human universals/human nature), like some other people (i.e., individual differences), and like no other person (i.e., idiosyncratic aspects of a person)*** (Kluckhohn & Murray, 1953). For example, aggression is part of human nature (i.e., humans evolved to exhibit aggression in some contexts), people vary in the degree to which they act aggressive, and each person has specific, idiosyncratic triggers of their aggression.
4. ***Understand individual differences at multiple levels of analysis*** (genotype, neural mechanisms, traits, goals, motives, narratives, and family, peer, school, and sociocultural contexts). The personality approach to psychological phenomena entails taking a biogenic (neurophysiological bases), sociogenic (social and cultural bases), and idiogenic (unique aspects of the person and their personality processes and dynamics) perspective (Little, 2017). Emphasize that individuals are biological beings, yet situated in a particular socio-cultural context that shapes the experience, expression, and meaning of personality. Researchers taking a personality approach need not incorporate each of these levels of analysis into any single study, but they should acknowledge the existence of multiple levels and work to incorporate as many as feasible. 5. ***Examine how individual-difference characteristics interact with social-contextual factors to shape behavior***. To what extent are there selection, evocation, and construal effects? That is, does the individual-difference construct predict which environments people end up in, how they modify those environments, and how they construe the features (affordances, opportunities, challenges) of the environment? 6. ***Examine developmental processes***. Study the factors (from genetic to sociocultural) that shape the development of the individual-difference construct. Examine normative changes in average levels of the construct across different developmental periods (e.g., childhood, adolescence, adulthood, and old age), and the extent to which the relative ordering of people remains stable over time. 7. ***Study people/behavior in naturalistic contexts and focus on real-world outcomes***. Examine the consequences of the individual-difference construct for a wide range of outcomes, including health and mortality, well-being, prosocial behavior, relationships, psychopathology, cognitive function, and school and work success. 8. ***Identify cognitive, affective, and behavioral mediators/mechanisms*** that explain how individual-difference constructs lead to particular behaviors and outcomes. 9. ***Identify situational triggers that explain when and why the individual-difference construct is expressed in particular contexts.***
Methodological aspects of the approach
10. ***Be obsessive about measurement issues***. Most widely used personality tests take years to develop and go through additional iterations to improve the quality of the measure years after the first version of the test was created. If an individual-difference measure is not psychometrically sound (reliable and valid), then findings using that measure are meaningless.
11. ***Use multi-method assessments***. Use the methodological toolkit shown in Table 1. Assume there is no gold standard assessment of any given construct, but rather each measure is fallible and provides partially valid, complementary information. Operationalize multi-method assessment by creating latent variable composites using structural equation modeling. Examine the robustness of findings across different assessment methods (i.e., conceptual replications).
12. ***Be "tough and tender"*** (Helson, 2008). Use rigorous quantitative methods (Big Five trait studies with large data sets) *and* more person-centered qualitative approaches, such as in-depth studies of individual personality processes and dynamics that do justice to the complexity of personality. 13. ***Follow people over time and across contexts/situations***. Both short-term (e.g., ESM) and long-term longitudinal studies are a hallmark of personality research, making it possible to examine how personality is expressed across different time scales (Hopwood et al., 2022). 14. ***Use meta-analysis (Bleidorn et al., 2021), mega-analysis (Beck & Jackson, 2022d), and integrative data analysis (Graham et al., 2017) to aggregate findings across studies*** and build a more cumulative and replicable research literature. 15. ***Emphasize effect sizes rather than significance levels***. Contextualize the interpretation of effect sizes appropriately and recognize that even small effects can be meaningful, especially when their effects accumulate over time (Funder & Ozer, 2019; Götz et al., 2022). 16. ***Encourage publishing purely descriptive research, null findings, and commonsense results***. Discourage the glorification of novel, counter-intuitive results. Ensure that studies have enough power to interpret null findings meaningfully. Do not be too wedded to theoretical conceptualizations of a construct and allow research findings to shape the interpretation (Clark & Watson, 2019; Loevinger, 1957).

The table is loosely organized around conceptual perspectives and methodological practices, but many points are both conceptual and methodological and could go into either category. Although no single study comes close to incorporating all aspects of the approach, in certain areas of research (e.g., personality and health), most, if not all, aspects of the approach are part of the broader program of research conducted by the collective research community. In the table we refer to "individual-difference constructs," rather than "personality constructs," to convey that the personality approach can be applied to a broader range of constructs than those traditionally conceptualized as personality.

TOWARD A MORE UNIFIED SOCIAL-PERSONALITY PSYCHOLOGY

We wrote this chapter with several broad goals in mind: Provide an overview of research in the field, show how personality research and theory can be used to understand an individual case, dispel some lingering myths about the field, articulate what it means to take a personality approach toward the study of psychological phenomena, increase social psychologists' interest in personality research, and promote collaboration between social and personality psychologists. To the extent that personality and social psychology can be seen as two distinct (but relatively similar) cultures within psychology (Funder & Fast, 2010; Tracy et al., 2009a), and given research showing that integrating one's different cultural backgrounds is beneficial (Benet-Martínez, 2021), the fields of personality and social psychology would benefit from being more blended. Although this integration already exists at the institutional level (e.g., a shared professional organization, *Society for Personality and Social Psychology* (SPSP), and shared journals such as *Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, Personality and Social Psychology Bulletin*, *Personality and Social Psychology Review*, and *Social Psychological and Personality Science*), the blending and integration of research questions, methods, and theories from the two subdisciplines is less evident at the level of individual researchers. This is unfortunate given that integration could lead to more innovative, multifaceted, and significant research.

Below, we offer several recommendations for how personality and social psychology research can become more methodologically and theoretically integrated, which we believe will improve the quality of research in both areas. First, simply being made aware of the differences between the two areas will help inform researchers of alternative ways of approaching their questions. It is typical for researchers studying a given phenomenon to look outside their field to other areas of psychology for new ways of studying a given construct; for example, attitude researchers look to cognitive psychology, emotion researchers to neuroscience, and trait researchers to developmental psychology. Researchers might just as fruitfully look across the social-personality divide for new methods and approaches. Novel answers to a social psychologist's question about why some people are more prejudiced than others, or to a personality researcher's question about the social-cognitive and situational processes that trigger narcissistic reactions in everyday interactions, may be found within the pages of *JPSP*—simply not the particular section these researchers typically turn to.

This leads to a second recommendation: social and personality researchers should more actively keep abreast of new theories and findings from the other area. This recommendation highlights the importance of societies such as SPSP and its associated journals and annual conference, which explicitly ensure coverage of both areas. Furthermore, given that most researchers tend to become well-versed in the research conducted by their local colleagues (which they learn about regularly

through area colloquia and graduate student committees), our findings point to the value of joint social-personality Ph.D. programs. Even departments that do not have joint areas can promote greater integration through colloquia that feature speakers from the complementary area.

We also recommend that researchers seek out collaborators from across the divide. If every researcher strove to collaborate on at least one project in their area of expertise with a researcher studying the same topic from the other area, novel findings would likely emerge, and both researchers would leave the collaboration with new ideas and insights. Such collaborations would be a fruitful way for researchers to conduct studies that directly incorporate both approaches by examining person × situation interactions. Interactions may be where the action lies for integrating social-personality research. As Lewin (1946) pointed out, persons, situations, and behaviors are all functions of each other, and consequently they should be studied in unison. Similarly, Cronbach (1957) noted that "correlational psychology studies only variance among organisms; experimental psychology studies only variance among treatments. A united discipline will study both of these, but it will also be concerned with the otherwise neglected interactions between organismic and treatment variables" (p. 681). It is hard to argue with two giants in the history of psychology.

Relatedly, adversarial collaborations between social and personality psychologists may prove fruitful. As noted earlier, social and personality researchers differ in their perspectives on the relative importance of situational vs. dispositional factors and the merits of different methodological approaches (albeit not to the extent that most think). Rather than allow these differences to foment conflict, it would be wise to convert these disagreements into more constructive adversarial collaborations. For example, many years ago, an author of this chapter was involved in a debate about whether high or low self-esteem is associated with aggression. Robins and colleagues argued, based on longitudinal studies with self and informant measures of aggression, that individuals with *low* self-esteem were more prone to aggression (e.g., Donnellan et al., 2005). In contrast, Baumeister and colleagues argued, based on experimental studies with lab-based measures of aggression (e.g., blasting the confederate with white noise), that individuals with *high* self-esteem were more likely to engage in aggression (e.g., Baumeister et al., 1996). Eventually, both groups of researchers moved on to other topics without resolving the seemingly conflicting findings. Clearly our understanding of this question would have benefitted from an adversarial collaboration in which we embedded repeated lab-based studies of self-esteem and aggression within the context of a long-term longitudinal study, ideally using a real-world intervention to increase self-esteem (Niveau et al., 2021) and conceptually similar measures of aggression and potential mediators and moderators of the effects. Instead, decades later, these same researchers continue to argue about the benefits of self-esteem (Krueger et al., 2022; Orth & Robins, 2022b), with little attempt at conceptual or methodological integration.

Our fourth recommendation is that, regardless of the importance individuals place on integrating social and personality research practices in their own studies, social-personality faculty should focus on educating and socializing their graduate students in the norms and practices of both sub-disciplines. Students should be taught the primary methods used in both areas and the complementary *value* of research practices from both areas (e.g., that studies with high internal validity, typically favored by social psychologists, should be supplemented by studies with high external validity, typically favored by personality psychologists, and vice versa). In addition to mentorship, this can be done through coursework featuring journal articles and chapters from both areas, as well as articles that adopt an interactionist approach. This also points to a need for broader textbooks (someone should write a textbook that provides an integrative social-personality perspective) and handbooks for undergraduate and graduate-level courses (a great example is

Deaux and Snyder's 2018 *Handbook of Personality and Social Psychology*). Within departments, personality and social faculty may wish to work together to identify the theoretical perspectives, assessment methods, research designs, statistical procedures and models, and causal inference guidelines that all social-personality students should be familiar with.

As a final recommendation, we suggest that journal editors and reviewers make conscious efforts to consider the potential benefits of an integrative approach. This way, authors could be reminded of complementary ways to think about or address their research questions. Editors and reviewers could even, at times, adopt the perspective of a 'watchdog' from the other stream—reminding authors of entrenched problems that individuals working mainly within their subfield tend to forget (e.g., the overreliance on self-report methods in personality research, and the artificiality of some experimental procedures in social psychology research). At the very least, knowledge of current and past research practices is a prerequisite for future research progress. We hope that this chapter has provided one small step toward this goal. Implementing the vision laid out in the latter sections of this chapter will require social and personality psychologists to work together and build on the strengths of each subfield. It is time we embraced the percipient words of Kurt Lewin, "General laws and individual differences are merely two aspects of one problem: they are mutually dependent on each other and the study of the one cannot proceed without the study of the other" (p. 794).

Personality is a vibrant area of psychological science that intersects with many other disciplines. Despite the abundance of unanswered questions and endless paths for future research, researchers have learned a considerable amount about the structure, development, and real-world consequences of personality since the founding of the field over 100 years ago. This is an exciting and opportune time for personality psychology. The field is well-positioned to play a significant role in the future of psychology as it moves toward more real-world, multilevel, multi-system, global, and interdisciplinary approaches and an increasing emphasis on the study of individual differences through precision science.

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ENDNOTES

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1. When asked why some prison guards refused to engage in abuse at Abu Ghraib, Zimbardo argued, "those are the rare people; those are the exceptions. We like to think we would be the heroes but in fact most of us, the majority, would go along, would blindly obey authority, would do these dehumanizing things to other people" (O'Brien, 2004, para. 23). In fact, at any given time, there were around 450 prison guards at Abu Ghraib (Higham et al., 2004). Only 11 guards were convicted of crimes and a few more faced disciplinary actions, which means the vast majority of guards were not convicted of engaging in abuse. No doubt some guards who committed atrocities were not caught or convicted, but given the public outcry and intense scrutiny the scandal elicited, it seems likely that most guards who engaged in criminally abusive behavior were identified and tried in military courts. ↑

2. A survey of social and personality psychologists found that social psychologists view situational factors as more important causes of behavior than stable dispositions and personality psychologists show the opposite pattern, but both groups rate the importance of situational *and* dispositional factors above the midpoint of the scale (Tracy et al., 2009a; 2009b). A more recent survey found that both social and personality psychologists believe personality is more influenced by environmental than non-environmental (e.g., genetic) factors, and nearly all respondents believe environmental factors have "some" or "a great deal of" influence on personality (Weidmann & Chopik, 2024). Thus, there is a divergence in emphasis, not the all-or-nothing stances assumed to characterize (and divide) social and personality psychologists. ↑

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4. In terms of our positionality vis a vis personality and social psychology, none of us consider ourselves purely personality psychologists, but rather as hybrids of personality-social-developmental (Robins, Lawson) and personality-social-cultural (Benet-Martinez). ↑

5. An analogous taxonomy for social psychologists would be a system for classifying all situations into a common framework, which would facilitate synthesis and integration of experimental findings that use a wide range of situational manipulations (see Rauthmann et al., 2014; 2020, for attempts to create such a taxonomy). ↑

6. Just as a strong situation can overwhelm individual differences in personality (Snyder & Ickes, 1985), President Trump's strong personality seemed impervious to the pervasive and powerful situational pressures of his role as President of the United States. ↑

7. The most widely used personality test in non-research settings, the Myers-Briggs Type Indicator (MBTI), has weak reliability and validity, classifies people into binary categories instead of assessing them on continuous dimensions, omits an important domain of personality (Neuroticism), and fails to predict relevant outcomes (Stephens-Davidowitz & Greenberg, 2024). Consequently, the MBTI is not considered a valid test and almost never used in research contexts. Similar problems plague another widely used personality test, the Enneagram Personality Test. ↑

8. In this context, personality psychologists often invoke the parable of the blind men and an elephant (first attributed to the Buddhist text Tittha Sutta). In this story, six blind men come across an elephant and seek to understand it and determine its nature. Touching different parts of the elephant, they in turn say, "It's a tree, it's a wall, it's a fan, it's a spear, it's a snake, it's a rope." Each man was sure his unique, limited experience led him to the truth. All of the men were partly right, but all were also partly wrong. ↑

9. Interestingly, people have some insight into how their personality changes following significant life events such as the death of a loved one and the onset of health problems; that is, participants' retrospective perceptions of how their personality changed followed these events showed some correspondence with measured changes in their personality test scores after the events (Schwaba, Denissen, et al., 2023). ↑

0. In contrast, motives, goals, values, self-esteem, and other non-trait personality constructs tend to be less heritable than traits and more influenced by environmental and sociocultural factors (Kandler et al., 2024; Lu et al., 2023). ↑

1. To avoid false positives, a *p*-level < .00000005 is used to correct for one million tests. ↑

2. Although often used interchangeably in everyday language, the distinction between self and personality is essentially a distinction between the perceiver and the object of perception. Personality characteristics such as shyness are theorized to exist within a person in a concrete objective sense (Funder, 1991), even if the ways in which we understand and assess these characteristics typically requires subjective judgments by self and others (from a philosophical perspective, personality characteristics can be considered ontologically real but epistemologically constructed). Thus, a person does not need to accurately perceive, or even perceive at all, their personality in order to have one, which is why human infants and non-human animals are assumed to have personalities (Weiss, 2021). An alternative way to think about the distinction between self and personality is that the self is a regulator of behavior and experience—it serves an executive function much like the driver of a car, where the car in this analogy is the individual's biologically based personality. The driver interprets the street signs (i.e., situational factors) and makes top-down inferences about how to prioritize competing goals and motives, and consequently individuals with a "race car driver" self-concept may speed and go through red lights, regardless of whether they have a Ferrari or Volvo-like personality. ↑

3. Ethnicity is a narrower construct than culture, referring to a shared ancestry that is distinctive and can be traced—for example, Hispanics in the U.S. share a common religion (Catholicism), language (Spanish), and history of Spanish colonization. ↑

4. In contrast, a recent study found relatively weak and inconsistent associations between child personality and adult political ideology, at least for traits related to "negativity bias", which is conceptually related to Neuroticism (Fasching et al., 2024). ↑

5. Using the same dataset, researchers found almost no replicable interactions among the Big Five in predicting life outcomes (Vize et al. 2023). This finding is contrary to most people's intuition that certain combinations of traits (e.g., being neurotic *and* disagreeable/antagonistic) would have synergistic effects above and beyond the individual effects of the traits. ↑